

A close-up, vertical shot of three iPhone 13 Pro smartphones stacked on top of each other. The top phone is silver, the middle one is orange, and the bottom one is dark blue. Each phone's back is visible, showing the triple-lens camera system (wide, telephoto, and ultrawide) and the LiDAR scanner. The phones are slightly offset horizontally, creating a layered effect. The lighting is soft, highlighting the metallic and matte finishes of the devices.

Exchange bonus up to ₹6000*



INGRAM MICRO | **Redington**

Printed at » Chennai » Coimbatore » Bengaluru » Hyderabad » Madurai » Noida » Visakhapatnam » Thiruvananthapuram » Kochi » Vijayawada » Mangaluru » Tiruchirappalli » Kolkata » Hubballi » Mohali » Malappuram » Mumbai » Lucknow » Cuttack » Patna

Price in Anna Nagar ~~₹15000/sft.~~

Price One Stop Away in West Mogappair

₹5199/sft.

(FOR FIRST 25 BOOKINGS ONLY)



8.8-acre community

114
amenities

**25300 sft.
clubhouse**



7700 sft.
swimming pool



6.7-acre
open space



52000 sft.
central park



LAUNCHING
**CASAGRAN
ZODIAC**

2, 3 & 4 BHK APTS. FROM ₹**64L** - ₹**1.36CR***
NEAR VELAMMAL VIDYALAYA

~~₹13000/- SFT.~~
KOYAMBEDU
MARKET PRICE

~~₹10500/-SFT.~~
MOGAPPAIR
MARKET PRICE

~~₹9000/-SFT~~
PORUR
MARKET PRICE

CASAGRAND
LAUNCH PRICE ~~₹ 5399/ SFT.~~

EARLY-BIRD
PRICE ₹5199/SFT.

HANDOVER IN 30 MONTHS

TOTAL UNITS - 764 | UNITS SOLD - 200 | AVAILABLE UNITS - 564

CREDAI

*T&C APPLY

EXCLUSIVE SITE VISIT AVAILABLE
VISIT MODEL HOUSE AT SITE

☎ 98848 30000



RERA NO:
TNRERA/2/BLG/0134/2026
WWW.RERA.TN.GOV.IN

PROMOTER ADDRESS:
NPL DEVI.111, LATTICE BRG RD,
THIRUVANMIYUR CHENNAI,
TAMIL NADU 600041



CASAGRAN
building aspirations



NEAR VELAMMAL VIDYALAYA

114
WORLD-CLASS
AMENITIES

Selfie Point, Water Stream,
Stepped Seating, Aromatic
Garden & 23 More

Giant Abacus, Mini Soccer,
TT Court, Box Cricket &
16 More

Yoga / Meditation Lawn,
Outdoor Crossfit &
2 More

Lap Pool, Sun Loungers,
Aqua Gym, Screening Wall
& 5 More

Level Seating, Leisure Plaza,
Sitout, Garden Sculpture &
16 More

Gym, AV Room,
Barbeque Zone, Rooftop
Theatre & 3 More

Indoor Play Area, Wall
Games, Air Hockey,
Foosball & 10 More

Kids Play Area & Creche,
Soft Play, Climbing Wall,
Sleeping Room & 4 More

Convenio Store, Business
Centre, Car Wash Bay &
2 More



LOCATION MAP

AMBATTUR RD.

AYAPPAKKAM

AYANAMBAKKAM ROAD

WEST MOGAPPAIR

CASAGRAN ZODIAC

VELAMMAL SCHOOL

VR MALL ANNA NAGAR

AACHI GLOBAL SCHOOL

SCHRAM ACADEMY

• KOYAMBEDU

• MADURAVOYAL

APPA SKYWALK MALL

• PORUR

POONAMALLEE ROAD

THIRUVERKADU

VANAGARAM-AMBATTUR ROAD

APOLLO NURSING COLLEGE

APOLLO HOSPITAL

MEENAKSHI DENTAL COLLEGE

MIOT HOSPITAL



*T&C APPLY

No.1
Ranked in Chennai
for last 8 years*

2 months
Guaranteed rental

Top 2
Ranked in
South India

6 months
Guaranteed resale

Top 7
Ranked in
India

7 years
Warranty

22+ years
of Trust &
Legacy

10 years
Maintenance by us

7000+
Homes sold in
FY'24 - 25

2000+
Quality checks

6 Cities

Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad,
Pune, Coimbatore & Dubai

On-time

Delivery of projects



PROMOTER ADDRESS:
NPL DEVI.111, LATTICE BRG RD,
THIRUVANMIYUR CHENNAI,
TAMIL NADU 600041



CASAGRAN
building aspirations

*Based on CBRE report 2024

Caasagrind Premier Builder Limited is proposing, subject to receipt of required approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offer of its equity shares and has filed a draft red herring prospectus (“DRHP”) with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (“SEBI”). The DRHP is available on the website of our Company, at www.caasagrind.com, the SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in as well as on the websites of the book running lead managers Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited and DAM Capital Advisors Limited at www.motilaloswalgroup.com and www.damcapital.in, respectively, and the websites of the stock exchange(s) at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com, respectively. Any potential investor should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see “Risk Factors” of the RHP, when available. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP filed with SEBI for making any investment decision. The Equity Shares have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act of 1933, as amended (“U.S. Securities Act”) or any other applicable law of the United States and, unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, the Equity Shares are being offered and sold outside the United States in “offshore transactions” as defined in and in compliance with Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur.



PICK-UP VEHICLE HITS TANKER
8 Karnataka pilgrims killed in A.P. accident
SOUTH » PAGE 11

CARBON EMISSION NORMS
Auto sector reaches consensus on CAFE-III
BUSINESS » PAGE 17





‘GRAVE SITUATION’
India, Austria discuss Iran, Ukraine conflicts
NEWS » PAGE 16

PARLEY
Should Mythos AI model raise security concern?
Govts., companies have reasons to worry
OPINION » PAGE 13



EMPHATIC VICTORY
Punjab Kings cruises past Mumbai Indians
SPORT » PAGE 19

NEARBY
▼


TVK releases poll manifesto

CHENNAI
Releasing the manifesto for the Assembly elections on Thursday, TVK president C. Joseph Vijay said that his party had only promised what was possible, practical, and implementable if voted to power. » **PAGE 10**



The Hindu has launched *Above the Fold*, a new flagship show on its YouTube platform, published at 10 p.m. on weekdays. This programme aims at providing in-depth coverage of the day's major developments, going beyond the headlines to offer added context, detailed analysis, and expert perspectives.
Watch *Above the Fold* at <https://www.youtube.com/@TheHinduOfficial>

FRIDAY REVIEW » 4 PAGES

South’s seat share won’t be cut, say PM and Shah

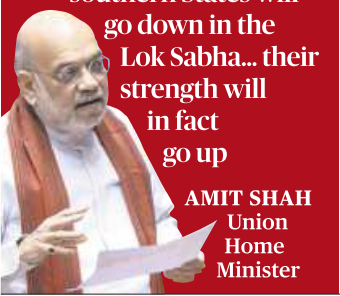
Amit Shah slams those ‘spreading misconceptions’; he tells Lok Sabha seats of five southern States will increase from 129 to 195 and reassures people of Tamil Nadu that their ‘power is increasing’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday told the Lok Sabha that the Bills to amend the women’s reservation law and carry out a fresh delimitation exercise will keep current proportional representation of southern States intact while increasing the absolute number of seats for each State approximately by 50%.

While the Prime Minister gave an assurance that the proportional distribution of seats among States will be maintained, the Home Minister gave a detailed scenario for each southern State after the three Bills become law.

The debate followed the introduction of three Bills: the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, to enable implementation of the women’s reservation by the 2029 Lok Sabha polls; the Delimitation Bill, 2026, to readjust parliamentary and Assembly constituencies through a Delimitation Commission; and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, to extend the reser-



A narrative is being spread that representation of southern States will go down in the Lok Sabha... their strength will in fact go up
AMIT SHAH
Union Home Minister

Proposed figures

The table shows the estimated number of seats for southern States as announced by Union Home Minister Amit Shah

State	Current seats	As a share of current 543 seats	50% increase (approx.)	New status (as a share of 816 seats)
Karnataka	28	5.15%	42	5.14%
Andhra Pradesh	25	4.60%	38	4.65%
Telangana	17	3.13%	26	3.18%
Tamil Nadu	39	7.18%	59	7.23%
Kerala	20	3.68%	30	3.67%
Total	129	23.76%	195	23.87%

vation to the legislatures of Delhi, Puducherry, and Jammu & Kashmir.

Mr. Shah said that as the Minister piloting the Bill, he was placing this interpretation before the House officially. “I understand my responsibility. Those who are spreading misconceptions perhaps do not understand,” he said.

Shah’s illustration

The Minister showed how the representation of the southern States would not go down. The Lok Sabha will have 816 seats after delimitation. He said that in a House of existing 543 members, Karnataka has 28 seats, or 5.15% of MPs. After the Bill is passed, Karnataka’s share will become

42, and its percentage of seats in a Lok Sabha of 816 members will be 5.14%. Andhra Pradesh, with its 25 seats (4.60%), will have 38 MPs (4.65%). Likewise, Telangana’s 17 seats (3.13%) will become 26 (3.18%), Kerala’s 20 seats (3.68%) will touch 30 (3.67%), and Tamil Nadu’s 39 seats (7.18%) will become 59 (7.23%).

Noting that many MPs from Tamil Nadu have come wearing black clothes, he reassured the people of the State that “your power is not decreasing, it is increasing.”

He said the number of Lok Sabha seats in the five southern States will go up from the existing 129 to 195, with the percentage

share increasing from 23.76% to 23.87%.

Participating in the debate, Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra slammed the delimitation and that “if the Constitution Amendment Bill is passed in Parliament, democracy will be finished in India”.

Former Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister and Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, while expressing support for the women’s reservation law, said it should be implemented only after the ongoing Census is complete.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 14**
RELATED STORIES ON
» **PAGES 14 & 15**



Stalin sets fire to a copy of the Delimitation Bill at a protest in Namakkal on Thursday. PTI

Stalin burns Delimitation Bill copy as T.N. protests

The Hindu Bureau
NAMAKKAL

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin burnt a copy of the Delimitation Bill in Namakkal as part of the statewide protest on Thursday. As the Bill was to be tabled in Parliament on the day, the DMK president called it a “conspiracy and a black law”.

The Chief Minister urged people to hoist black flags in every home and public place on Thursday. He hoisted a black flag at Nallipalayam in Namakkal and raised slogans that “Tamil Nadu will protest and Tamil Nadu will win”.

Adi Dravidar Welfare Department Minister M. Mathiiventhan, Rajya Sabha member K.R.N. Rajeshkumar and DMK functionaries took part in the protest.

Trump announces ceasefire between Lebanon and Israel

Stanly Johny

U.S. President Donald Trump on Thursday announced a 10-day ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon, effective from midnight.

“I just had excellent conversations with the Highly Respected President Joseph Aoun, of Lebanon, and Prime Minister Bibi Netanyahu, of Israel. These two Leaders have agreed that in order to achieve PEACE between their Countries, they will formally begin a 10-day ceasefire at 5 P.M. EST,” Mr. Trump wrote in a social media post.

The ceasefire, if comes into effect, could strengthen the two-week U.S.-Iran ceasefire which was announced on April 8. Extending the truce to Lebanon has been one of the key demands of Iran. When Mr. Trump announced the Iran truce, Israel said Lebanon was not part of it and stepped up strikes on the country.

Hezbollah part of deal

Mr. Trump said the ceasefire would include Iran-backed Hezbollah. “Today they’re going to be having a ceasefire, and that’ll include Hezbollah,” Mr. Trump told presspersons at the White House.



Smoke rises from Kfar Tibnit, a Lebanese village attacked by Israel, on Thursday. AFP

Mr. Netanyahu said that the 10-day ceasefire with Lebanon offered an opportunity for a “historic peace agreement” with Beirut, but insisted that the disarmament of militant group Hezbollah remained a precondition.

“We have an opportunity to make a historic peace agreement with Lebanon,” he said in a televised speech, adding that Israel will maintain a 10-km “security zone” along the border in southern Lebanon.

Hezbollah lawmaker Ibrahim al-Moussawi told AFP that the Lebanese group would respect a ceasefire if Israeli attacks on the militants stopped.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 14**
MUNIR MEETS GHALIBAF
» **PAGE 18**

Electors cleared by tribunals till April 21 and 27 can vote: SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has declared that electors who were purged from the voter list during the West Bengal special intensive revision, but subsequently cleared by Appellate Tribunals by April 21 or April 27 must be allowed to vote in the Assembly election.

The order by a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant spelt a huge reprieve for citizens whose right to vote was denied in the SIR under the “logical discrepancy” category. Over 34 lakh appeals were filed as on April 11.

The court, issuing directions in exercise of its extraordinary constitutional powers under Article 142, ordered the Election Commission to publish a “supplementary revised electoral roll” containing the names of those who won their appeals by April 21, ahead of the first phase of polling in the State on April 23, or by April 27, prior to the second phase on April 29.

“Wherever the Appellate Tribunals are able to decide the appeals by April 21 or April 27, as the case may be, such appellate orders shall be given effect to by issuing a supplement-

Individuals with appeals pending before tribunals will not be allowed to vote in the 2-phased West Bengal polls

tary revised electoral roll, and all necessary consequences with respect to the right to vote shall follow. However, it goes without saying that the mere pendency of appeals preferred by excluded persons before the Appellate Tribunals shall not entitle them to exercise their right to vote,” the court ordered.

However, those whose appeals remain pending before the tribunals would not be allowed to vote. The order is dated April 13, but published on April 16.

On April 13, the court had orally observed that the right to be on the electoral roll and to vote in one’s own country was not only constitutional but sentimental.

It had referred to thousands of voters excluded for “logical discrepancies” and lined up for appeal hearings in West Bengal barely a few days ahead of the Assembly election.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 14**



Reindeer International School
Yercaud Hills, Tamil Nadu
KNOWLEDGE * EMPOWER * WISDOM



CAMBRIDGE
International Education
Cambridge International School

Fully Residential / Weekly Boarding

ADMISSIONS OPEN
2026-27
Grade 1 – Grade 8

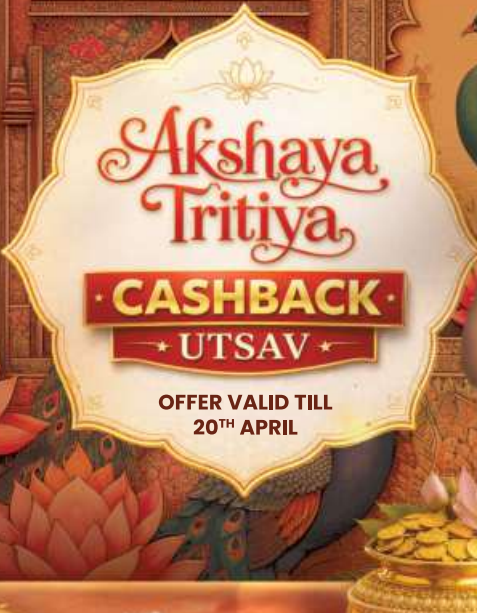




Contact Us
04281-299999
+91 95002 52728
APPLY NOW
www.reindeerschools.com



Joyalukkas
World's favourite jeweller
Shop online @ joyalukkas.com



Akshaya Tritiya
CASHBACK
UTSAV
OFFER VALID TILL 20TH APRIL

FREE
₹2000
GIFT VOUCHER

on purchase of diamond, uncut diamond & platinum jewellery worth ₹ 75,000 and above

FREE
₹1000
GIFT VOUCHER

on purchase of gold and precious jewellery worth ₹ 75,000 and above

FREE
₹500
GIFT VOUCHER

on purchase of silver jewellery worth ₹ 15,000 and above

PAY 10% AND LOCK TODAY'S GOLD RATE
UNTIL 2ND MAY 2026

SELL YOUR OLD GOLD FROM ANY JEWELLER AND GET INSTANT CASH IN 15 MINUTES

CHENNAI: NORTH USMAN ROAD, T. NAGAR | PRASHANTH GOLD TOWER, T. NAGAR | ANNA NAGAR | CHROMEPET | VELACHERY • PUDUCHERRY: COMBATORE CROSS CUT ROAD | PERIYA KADAVUETTU 100 FEET ROAD • TIRUPUR • Erode • Salem • Vellore • Nagercoil • RAMANATHAPURAM • MADURAI: NETHAJI ROAD | WEST VELU STREET • KUMBakonam • KANCHI • Cuddalore • Tirunelveli • Trichy • Thanjavur • Marthandam

INDIA • USA • UK • UAE • Oman • Qatar • Bahrain • KSA • Kuwait • Singapore • Malaysia • Australia

INBRIEF



BIS organises programme on safety standards for toys

The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) organised an awareness programme on safety requirements prescribed under the Indian Standard (IS) for toys, here on Thursday. A press release said the programme was organised to create awareness among stakeholders, particularly toy manufacturers and retailers, regarding IS 9873 (part 1): 2025 - Safety of Toys. The session aimed at encouraging the adoption of standards in manufacturing practices to ensure safer products for children and enhance reliability in the domestic toy industry. R. Muninarayana, Director, BIS Chennai, spoke about the importance of adherence to standards in the toys manufacturing sector.

Text & Context and Health

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 17, Friday), the following articles are available:

■ On the Sabarimala temple entry case newsth.live/DG652a

■ Why India should establish a vaccine injury compensation mechanism newsth.live/vaccinecomp

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Housing for roadside dwellers, providing solution to traffic issues are top priorities'

DMK's Harbour constituency candidate P.K. Sekarbabu says 3,000 housing units are being planned and a multi-level car parking facility is under construction in Broadway. Other priorities include uninterrupted supply of electricity and safe drinking water, and more educational institutions

INTERVIEW

P.K. Sekarbabu

R. Aishwaryaa
CHENNAI

In the midst of hectic campaigning, Minister for Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments and sitting MLA of Harbour Assembly constituency, P.K. Sekarbabu, discussed with *The Hindu* his roadmap for improving the locality.

His priorities include providing housing for roadside dwellers, establishing parking facilities, and expanding educational centres.

Here are the edited excerpts:

What is the first issue you intend to address if elected back to power in 2026?

The topmost priority is to provide housing for roadside or canal-side dwellers. For this, we are preparing a plan to construct at least



B. JOTHI RAVILINGAM

3,000 multi-storey housing units.

Increasing the number of educational institutions, learning centres, and libraries will also be prioritised. Importance will be given to providing uninterrupted power supply, safe drinking water, and proper sewer systems.

There are parking and congestion problems here despite major

transport services. How will you look at addressing these?

A multi-level car parking facility is being constructed in Broadway. It is expected to be completed in two years.

Once operational, the traffic congestion in areas such as Sowcarpet will be reduced. We will transform this congested constituency by implementing

measures to regulate traffic.

There are many illegal encroachments due to the large number of shops and migrant workers. How will this be handled in the future?

We give importance to development work, but we will not forcibly evict anyone. We have not re-

moved any shops previously either. If there are essential needs that require action like relocation, it will be done only after considering their alternative domicile location, their day-to-day activities, and their livelihood.

Stray cattle and street dog menace is also being reported. When will this be controlled?

To address this [stray cattle issue], the Corporation constructed a large cattle shelter adjoining Thiru.Vi-Ka Nagar and Royapuram Zones. There are already about 1,200 cattle there. These will be expanded further. The situation [stray cattle menace] is better now, compared to previous years. In the next phase, the issue will be completely resolved.

How have the MLA funds been used?

Over the past 10 years of my tenure, the MLA funds have been fully utilised. The first thing I did in 2016 was to start a training insti-

tute in this area. In the first phase, courses including beautician training, tailoring, and computer training were started. Now, 6,300 people have completed their training there.

In Harbour constituency alone, three study centres were set up, and two more are being constructed – on Prakasam Road and Wall Tax Road. For roadside dwellers, 1,470 housing units, each measuring 425 sq.ft., were built. Of these, allotment orders have been issued for 770 units.

Similarly, on Thanneer Thotti Street, a large complex spanning 6.4 acres, with 700 housing units, has been allotted to and is occupied by erstwhile roadside dwellers. Likewise, 140 houses are under construction in the constituency, with facilities such as a gym, hospital, ration shop, and anganwadis.

A playground spread over two acres, an air-conditioned marriage hall, and a modern printing press for the Corporation too, were set up. A dialysis centre and physiotherapy unit will also come up.

Vijay, TVK functionaries booked for poll code violations during campaign

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The city police have filed cases against TVK president C. Joseph Vijay and party functionaries at the West Mambalam, Nungambakkam, and Vepery police stations for conducting roadshows in alleged violation of the poll code.

The cases were filed based on complaints from election observers and flying squad officials, who said the campaign events breached the conditions im-

posed under the Model Code of Conduct.

At West Mambalam, the police registered a case against Mr. Vijay, T. Nagar constituency candidate N. Anand, and another of-fice-bearer of the party.

'Hindered traffic'

The complaint, filed by Flying Squad Officer Santhosh Kumar, alleged that instead of the permitted meeting, the group conducted a roadshow, which exceeded the approved gathering limit and hindered traffic.

A case was booked under Section 223 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and relevant provisions.

In a separate incident, a case was registered against Mr. Vijay and the Thousand Lights constituency candidate J.C.D. Prabhakar for conducting a roadshow near Valluvar Kottam without permission.

Similarly, the Vepery police registered a case against Mr. Vijay and Egmore constituency candidate Rajmohan for organising a roadshow in violation of election guidelines.

Election officials seize gold jewellery worth ₹245 cr.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A static surveillance team, on Thursday, seized gold jewellery worth ₹245 crore from a

container lorry in Adyar for not gaining permission from the Election Commission for transporting them. The consignment was later handed over to the IT Department.

The vehicle was intercepted at the Adyar Bridge Road-Vasanthapress Road junction, opposite MGM Hospital.

The consignment was under the custody of Ismail, 33, a

delivery assistant with Sequel Global Precious Logistics in Pallavaram. The driver, Ranjith, was transporting the jewellery from Sowcarpet to the company's office.

High Court dismisses Karti Chidambaram's writ for speedy disposal of plea to de-freeze salary account

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Thursday dismissed a writ petition filed by Congress Member of Parliament (MP) Karti P. Chidambaram, 54, representing Sivaganga constituency, and refused to direct the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), Chennai Bench, to expeditiously dispose of a plea made by him to order the defreezing of his salary account.

Justices S.M. Subramaniam and K. Surender said any such direction would amount to exerting "unnecessary pressure" on the tribunal to dispose of cases out of turn and not let the judicial forum decide them in a "systematic manner." The High Court must exercise restraint when it comes to directing trial courts/tribunals to dispose of cases expeditiously, they said.

Making it clear that such directions could be issued only in exceptional circumstances, the judges said, in normal circumstances, a direction of such nature would result in imposing "unnecessary burden" on the tribunals. In the present case, Mr. Karti Chidambaram had filed an interlocutory application before the NCLT on April 8, and moved the High Court with the present writ petition on April 9, they said.

"No effective steps have been taken by the petitioner to ventilate his grievance before the NCLT, but a writ petition has been filed seeking a direction for speedy disposal. It may be an easy way out for the petitioner, but it would result in unnecessary pressure on the tribunal," the judges wrote. They also said a direction for speedy disposal of select cases might cause prejudice to other litigants waiting for a long time.

Justice Subramaniam wrote: "As far as litigants are concerned, howsoever high they may be, all of them have to be treated as equal when their cases are dealt with by the courts... In the present case, the petitioner has not even allowed the tribunal to consider the interlocutory application and filed the present writ petition on the very next day of the filing of such interlocutory application."

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy Madras Today: At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall from 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. – Swathi Tirunal Day - Bhavana Iyer (Vocal), S. Subhashree (Violin), Srivanchi R. Sri Ram (Mridangam) – Programme under the endowment instituted by M/s. Arun Fabricators.

Naada Inbam, 24992672
Today 6.15pm Dr. Rajshri Ramakrishna - Veena, S. Govindarajan. Concert supported by Vainika R. Ramani. Ragasudha Hall.

Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation, Ch-4.
Today at 06.30 pm UAA in its 74th Year Y Gee Mahendra in & as Varadukutti Parithaikalku Neramachu - 2 Drama Written by G Radhakrishnan Directed by Y.GEE Mahendra Ph. No: 8610357987. Rasikas Welcome.

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha (Regd) Vanimahahal, Ph: 28152166
Today 5 pm at Vani Mahal Pan-niru Thirumurai by Sri Manikavasakan Othuvai. 7pm: Panniru Thirumurai by Sri Sath-gurunathan. B. Othuvai All are welcome.

I. HAJEERA Banu, w/o: Balaraman Vasudevan, r/o: 23, Rajiv Gandhi, 2nd Street, Lakshmi-puram, Thirunelmalai, Chompet, Tam-baram – 600044. Have changed my name as Sivakami Govindasamy.

I. SIVAKAMI Vasudevan, w/o: Balaraman Vasudevan, r/o: 23, Rajiv Gandhi, 2nd Street, Lakshmi-puram, Thirunelmalai, Chompet, Tam-baram – 600044. Have changed my name as Sivakami Govindasamy.

MISCELLANEOUS

C.P. ART CENTRE
1 Eldama Road, Alwarpet, Chennai - 18
Exhibition of Photographs by JINA PARK
on
LYRICAL ENCOUNTERS: INDIA THROUGH A KOREAN LENS
Inauguration by
MR. CHANG-NYUN KIM
Consul General, Consulate General of the Republic of Korea in Chennai
Today at 11 am
The Exhibition will remain open from April 17 to 26, 2026 11 a.m. to 7 p.m.

To advertise visit
www.thehinduads.com
☎ 044-28576300
☎ Toll Free: 1800 102 4161

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The RV Experience (Retro to Rockstar)

VEENA MAESTRO
Rajhesh Vaidhya
- LIVE -
TOMORROW (APRIL 18) 6.30pm
VANI MAHAL A/C, T. Nagar

CLASSIFIEDS MART

TO ADVERTISE VISIT
www.thehinduads.com
CALL: 044-28576300 • TOLL FREE: 1800 102 4161
or Contact your nearest Authorised space sellers

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, ARTHI R, daughter of Thiru V. Ram-an, born on 17th November 1981 (District of birth: Villupuram), residing at SD, 6th Block, Jains Abhishek Apartments, 173, Velachery Main Road, Selayur, Chennai – 600073, shall henceforth be known as ARTHI GANESH

I, HAJEERA Banu, wife of Thiru Saj-jad Hussain, born on 15th April 1963 (District of Birth: Chennai), residing at No. 15/4, Thakkudin Khan Street, Triplicane, Chennai-600 005, shall henceforth be known as AZRA BEE BEE.Chennai, 28th November 2025.HAJEERA BANU

I, SIVAKAMI Vasudevan, w/o: Balaraman Vasudevan, r/o: 23, Rajiv Gandhi, 2nd Street, Lakshmi-puram, Thirunelmalai, Chompet, Tam-baram – 600044. Have changed my name as Sivakami Govindasamy.

SITUATION VACANT

MARKETING

BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT Exe.& Man-agers Wanted for an Engineering Co@ Thirumazhisai SIDCO WhatsApp 9789011077

MEDICAL

SUGAM HOSPITALS
THIRUVOTRIYUR, Ch-19
Requires
Full time Physician as a Consultant and also as Faculty for DNB course & Full Time Pediatrician
99622 71160
hrd.sugam@gmail.com

WALK – IN

"WALK-IN-INTERVIEW"
Ace Infotexis Pvt Ltd requires following Manpower for their reputed Govt Clients at Chennai. Candidates with relevant qualifications & experience may come for Walk in Interview on Saturday 18th April 2026 from 10 am to 4 pm at address:-
● **Health & Safety Officer** 1 No PG Diploma in Fire & Industrial Safety Management/Health Safety and Environment Experience:- 2-5 Years CTC(approx):- 37,850/-
● **Engineer** 10 Nos Graduate in Engineering Disciplines (Elect., Mech., S&T, Civil etc.) Experience:- 7+Year CTC(approx):- 43,740/-
● **Technical Assistant** 156 Nos Diploma in Engineering discipline Experience:- 5-7 Years CTC(approx):- 28,640/-
16 Greams Road, BSNL building, 2nd floor, Chennai- 600006. ariya.a@acemampowers.com M: 7489270711, 9174001015

EDUCATIONAL

VACANCIES

WANTED HR.SEC. experienced PGTS in Maths. Attractive Salary offered for right candidates. Walk – in. Christ The King Matric Hr.Sec School, Medavakkam, Chennai 100. ctkmhss@gmail.com. 95660 24491.

NETLON SAINTGOBAIN SS Doortype SV Trading Authorised Deal-er:9940386715

REQD STOREKEEPER and Maintenance Near Sripurambudur. Ct: 81442 20958

SR. CITIZENS Rtd Govt & Pvt, VRS 50 – 65 with Sal Upto 75K 9500438189

HIRING EMPOWER Leaders-team Mgr/ Fin Ct:8825807168

MNC SR.OFFICER Admin Role Project Leader & Sr.Account Manager upto 70K + PF Age: 40/ Retired: 9560222559

GENERAL

REQD STOREKEEPER and Maintenance Near Sripurambudur. Ct: 81442 20958

SR. CITIZENS Rtd Govt & Pvt, VRS 50 – 65 with Sal Upto 75K 9500438189

HIRING EMPOWER Leaders-team Mgr/ Fin Ct:8825807168

MNC SR.OFFICER Admin Role Project Leader & Sr.Account Manager upto 70K + PF Age: 40/ Retired: 9560222559

SITUATION VACANT

MARKETING

BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT Exe.& Man-agers Wanted for an Engineering Co@ Thirumazhisai SIDCO WhatsApp 9789011077

MEDICAL

SUGAM HOSPITALS
THIRUVOTRIYUR, Ch-19
Requires
Full time Physician as a Consultant and also as Faculty for DNB course & Full Time Pediatrician
99622 71160
hrd.sugam@gmail.com

WALK – IN

"WALK-IN-INTERVIEW"
Ace Infotexis Pvt Ltd requires following Manpower for their reputed Govt Clients at Chennai. Candidates with relevant qualifications & experience may come for Walk in Interview on Saturday 18th April 2026 from 10 am to 4 pm at address:-
● **Health & Safety Officer** 1 No PG Diploma in Fire & Industrial Safety Management/Health Safety and Environment Experience:- 2-5 Years CTC(approx):- 37,850/-
● **Engineer** 10 Nos Graduate in Engineering Disciplines (Elect., Mech., S&T, Civil etc.) Experience:- 7+Year CTC(approx):- 43,740/-
● **Technical Assistant** 156 Nos Diploma in Engineering discipline Experience:- 5-7 Years CTC(approx):- 28,640/-
16 Greams Road, BSNL building, 2nd floor, Chennai- 600006. ariya.a@acemampowers.com M: 7489270711, 9174001015

EDUCATIONAL

VACANCIES

WANTED HR.SEC. experienced PGTS in Maths. Attractive Salary offered for right candidates. Walk – in. Christ The King Matric Hr.Sec School, Medavakkam, Chennai 100. ctkmhss@gmail.com. 95660 24491.

NETLON SAINTGOBAIN SS Doortype SV Trading Authorised Deal-er:9940386715

REQD STOREKEEPER and Maintenance Near Sripurambudur. Ct: 81442 20958

SR. CITIZENS Rtd Govt & Pvt, VRS 50 – 65 with Sal Upto 75K 9500438189

HIRING EMPOWER Leaders-team Mgr/ Fin Ct:8825807168

MNC SR.OFFICER Admin Role Project Leader & Sr.Account Manager upto 70K + PF Age: 40/ Retired: 9560222559

GENERAL

REQD STOREKEEPER and Maintenance Near Sripurambudur. Ct: 81442 20958

SR. CITIZENS Rtd Govt & Pvt, VRS 50 – 65 with Sal Upto 75K 9500438189

HIRING EMPOWER Leaders-team Mgr/ Fin Ct:8825807168

MNC SR.OFFICER Admin Role Project Leader & Sr.Account Manager upto 70K + PF Age: 40/ Retired: 9560222559

REAL ESTATE

CONSULTANTS

BUILDING PLAN Approval 25yr Ser-vice & Expd in TP Dept/GCC. 8825530329

SELLING

ADYAR PRIME Brand New Retail Space 5500 Sqft with Rental Returns Cos-mic Properties 90907 55000

GUINDY (BEHIND Race Course) Rent Yielding Commercial Bldg (14000 Sqft) on 3 Grounds, Cosmic Prop-erties 99400 76667

MANAPAKKAM MAIN Road 2 Grounds With Bldg Cosmic Properties 99400 76667

BEHIND ORAGADAM Sipcot 15 & 25 Acres Land Suitable for Industrial /Warehouse Avbl Good Return on In-vestments Assured Cosmic Prop-erties 95000 80999

WALAJABAD UTHUKADU Approved Indus-trial Plots From 20000 Sqft On-wards Bank Loans Avbl for Purchase Cosmic Properties 90477 34343

SUNGUVARCHATRAM 25ACRES Dry Land & Close to Upcoming Bangalore Ex-press Highway Suitable for Indus-try & Warehouse Cosmic Properties 90477 34343

35 ACRES on Chennai to Tirupathi Highway Before Periyapalayam & Be-hind Chennai Peripheral Ring Road Cosmic Properties 90477 34343

KANCHIPURAM NEAR Vellaigalate & NH, 2Acres for Commercial Land, Per Acre Rs.3Cr 9894715290 / 9894715289

FARMHOUSE / LAND / RESORTS

VEPPAMPATTU (8GR) 19500sqft 3.2Km From MTH Road 25L/Ground. 9884088660

MAHINDRA CITY Near D-Mart 35000sqft For Rent. Suitable For Godown, Warehouse, Office. Ct: 9884675805

GODOWN CUM Office, 8,000 Sq Ft. near Ayanavaram Bus Depot. 9840066760.

RENT: PREMIUM Office, Retail, Show-room Spaces Across Chennai. Star Ocean Assets: 9840955510

ADYAR, GANDHINAGAR, 3408 Sq.ft. S + 3 Floors. Ideal for Retail / Of-fice / Restaurants. Bysani Prop-erty Advisors: 9789000737

MEDAVAKKAM On Rd Ragamallika Phase-1, 1st Floor 12168.1463 Sft. Lift, Office/Showroom Rent:9597088298

RESIDENTIAL FLAT – RESALE

ADYAR GANDHI Nagar 2BHK 1025 Sft 1.6cr. 81300 Sft 1.8cr.Nego. 9941767671

RESIDENTIAL HOUSE

KILPAUK KELLYS Indep House 7BHK G+2 1.5 Gr Quiet Location 99622 64294

VANAGARAM VALIYAMAL Ngr 1300sf(L) G+2Fr 1 & 2Bhk 1.99Cr CCP 9080213069

NEW 3BHK Duplex House Ready. 1840sf in 1050sf Land Chromepet Ngr Thirumalai Nagar, Zion School. 9962246773

RESIDENTIAL LAND

SRIPERUMBUDUR TOLL Plaza CMDA Vil-la Plots Rs.4000/-per sft 98408 05512

REDHILLS NR 400ft Rd Vijaya Garden Residents 12200sf UnApproved Plot Per sft Rs.1200 No Brks 70107 89509

MINJUR NANDIYAMBAKKAM Nr Rly Stn CMDA Plot Ready to Build 944628550 9940046232

NERKUNDRAM, 3500 Sq.ft Land. Rs. 4.85 Crores. Bysani Property Advi-sors: 9789000737

GOPALAPURAM 3200 Sq ft land with frontage 40ft in Prime location 14108

PAMMAL, NALLATHAMBI Road, 2400 Sq.ft Plot @ Rs. 2.15Cr, 1200 Sq.ft. also available @ Rs.1.10 Crore. Call : 9894715293, 8925819495

WEST TAMBARAM, Varadarajapuram, 2400 Sq.Ft / 1200 Sq.Ft plot also available @ Rs.2600 per Sq.Ft. Ct 9840972961, 8925819495

CHROMPET NR Super Saravana Stores, 1700sf & 3740sf available CMDA apd Rs. 7500/sft 9894715293, 9840972961

NEELANGARAI POSH Elite 7740sf 11.55 Cr DD & Padur 1805sf 55L 9841105393

FACTORIES & SITES

ORAGADAM SIPCOT behind 16,000Sqft Warehouse for Rent. Cont 99341473000

MM.NAGAR TO Sripurambudur 40,000Sft to 10,000 Sft available for Rent.Contact: Srinivasan: 7448314831

GENERAL

RENTALS OF Comrol/ Resi Bungalows, Floor Villas, Pent Houses & Villas Call: M/s. Villas World- 7358442929

RESIDENTIAL

ADYAR

ADYAR ULTRA Modern & Brand New 4BHK Apt 2450 Sqft With 2CCP Cos-mic Properties 95000 72727

ASHOK NAGAR

19TH AV 1800Sft 3BHK CCP FF Indep. House Immed Occupation 9444405333

EAST COAST ROAD

ECR PANAIYUR Villa 4BHK 4000 Sqft pool CarPark. Ct 9841040212

EKKADUTHANGAL

DEFENCE COLONY, Ekkattuthangal, In-dependent House Ground Flr, about 2400 sft 4 Bedrooms Bath 3 At-tached One Common Dining Drawing One Covered Car Park 8838852009 / 9445006969

COMMERCIAL

PERIAMET Raja Muthaiah Salai

Newly renovated 20 rooms attached bathrooms for rent. NO FURNITURE

WHATSAPP CALL 0064278007786

MAHINDRA CITY Near D-Mart 35000sqft For Rent. Suitable For Godown, Warehouse, Office. Ct: 9884675805

GODOWN CUM Office, 8,000 Sq Ft. near Ayanavaram Bus Depot. 9840066760.

RENT: PREMIUM Office, Retail, Show-room Spaces Across Chennai. Star Ocean Assets: 9840955510

ADYAR, GANDHINAGAR, 3408 Sq.ft. S + 3 Floors. Ideal for Retail / Of-fice / Restaurants. Bysani Prop-erty Advisors: 9789000737

MEDAVAKKAM On Rd Ragamallika Phase-1, 1st Floor 12168.1463 Sft. Lift, Office/Showroom Rent:9597088298

COMMERCIAL

OFFICE CLINIC 1800sqft open space 1st floor 3 cabins A/C, Reception Table, car park, Ct: 9840056007

ANNANAGAR 7TH-MAIN Rd 850Sft Com-mercial Flat Gr.Flr 20CP.Ct 9840060608

ADYAR PRIME 6000sqft. Commercial Space. Ph: 9444728899 / 9940697989.

CHETPET MCNICHOLS Rd 100 sft each 1 & II fls. 94441 66156, 97103 98622

FULLY FURNISHED Office @ Greams Road, Nungambakkam, TTK Rd. 9884004648

FOR RENT

Commercial space for Rent opp to Simco meter KK Nagar Trichy, Stilt +4 Floors with Lift Facility, Each Floor carpet area of 2000 sq ft 9443159023





RERA : TNRERA/35/BLG/0018/2026
www.rera.tn.gov.in



Ungal **Vote** Yaaruku??

YOUR VOTE. **YOUR HOME.** YOUR WIN.

LAUNCHING



KOLAPAKKAM

OFF VANDALUR-KELAMBAKKAM ROAD

MARKET PRICE
~~₹73L~~
ISHA PRICE
~~₹70L~~

2 & 3 BHK
PREMIUM
APARTMENTS
EXCITING LAUNCH PRICE

₹66L*
onwards

*T&C Apply





173 UNITS | 930 TO 1238 SQ.FT.

WINNING LOCATION

Landscaped Garden | Jogging Track | EV Charging



COLLEGES

- Annai Velankanni Engg. College - 2.1 km
- Balaji Arts & Science College - 2.1 km
- Ramanujam Engg. college - 2.5 km
- Crescent University - 3.6 km
- Tagore Engg. College - 4.0 km
- Tagore Medical & Dental College - 4.5 km
- VIT - 7.3 km
- Bharath University - 9.0 km
- SRM University - 13 km

IT COMPANIES

- Shriram Gateway IT - 6 km
- Zoho - 11 km
- MEPZ - 12 km
- SIPCOT - 19 km
- ELCOT SEZ - 19 km

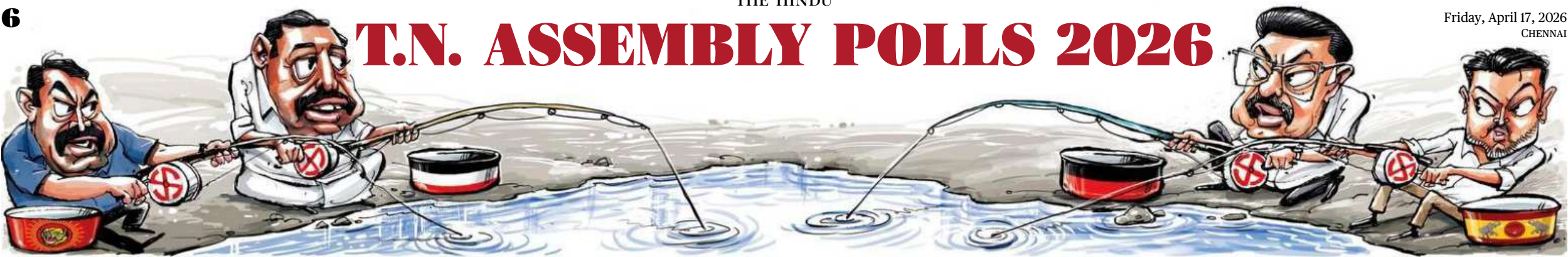
WINNING
FEATURES **5** **PROMISES**
WORK. PLAY. CONNECT. GROW. RELAX.

IN THE MIDST OF A WELL-ESTABLISHED RESIDENTIAL NEIGHBORHOOD



99860 23056
080 6273 8851





Natraj was fielded by the AIADMK in the Mylapore constituency, and went on to become an MLA.

Transferred by EC for praising Jayalalithaa, this ex-IPS officer became an AIADMK MLA

D. Suresh Kumar
CHENNAI

On International Women's Day in 2006, while Tamil Nadu was headed for Assembly elections, Greater Chennai Commissioner of Police R. Natraj told a newspaper: "Chief Minister Jayalalithaa is the perfect example of the ideal woman. I think she is an icon, and every woman should look up to her."

DMK leader A. Raja lodged a complaint with the Election Commission of India (EC), contending that since the Commissioner had praised the Chief Minister, he could not be depended upon to ensure a "free and fair poll" in the Greater Chennai region.

EC directive

The EC directed the State government to transfer Mr. Natraj. The Jayalalithaa government, however, urged the EC to reconsider its decision. The poll body declined. Thereafter, the State Home Secretary moved the Madras High Court, challenging the EC's decision. "The said officer is a senior police officer, with a commendable track record and impeccable integrity. His official conduct in the discharge of duties has been constantly fair and impartial," he said. Transferring him for expressing his personal views appeared too harsh and incorrect, he added.

Two former DGPs, Walter I. Davaram and Pon. Paramaguru, also moved the court, challenging the decision.

The court ruled that the EC order was not binding on the State. The EC went to the Supreme Court, arguing: "The Commission, after carefully considering the issue in all its aspects, was of the opinion that when an officer, by his own public statement, shows a positive leaning towards a particular leader of the ruling party, his impartiality, objectivity, and neutrality definitely come under question."

While its Special Leave Petition was being heard, the EC insisted that the State send a list of three IPS officers who could be considered as a replacement for Mr. Natraj. The EC eventually appointed Letika Saran as Commissioner. Mr. Natraj later retired as DGP of Fire and Rescue Services, and was appointed Tamil Nadu Public Service Commission Chairman. He also challenged Ms. Saran's subsequent appointment as DGP.

In April 2014, he joined the AIADMK. "I received the primary membership card from the party leader today...my entry is formalised. I see this as an opportunity to reach out to the people. Ms. Jayalalithaa is good at conceptualising and implementing welfare schemes," he said.

A faux pas

But nearly 20 months later, he was taken aback when Jayalalithaa expelled him from the party. Interestingly, what led to his expulsion was a faux pas by a Tamil TV channel, which inadvertently attributed to him a comment critical of the Jayalalithaa government, made by a former journalist named R. Natarajan. The TV channel apologised. A day later, Jayalalithaa merely issued a statement that her previous day's order stood cancelled. In effect, Mr. Natraj's expulsion was revoked. "I knew that once facts are placed before *Amma* (Jayalalithaa), justice will be rendered in no time. I will continue to serve the people," he said.

The following year, Jayalalithaa decided to reward Mr. Natraj for his loyalty. She fielded him in the Mylapore Assembly constituency as an AIADMK candidate, and he went on to become an MLA. After Jayalalithaa's death in December 2016, Mr. Natraj was briefly associated with the camp led by former Chief Minister O. Panneerselvam. In 2021, he lost to the DMK's Velu. In the upcoming election, the Mylapore constituency has been allotted by the AIADMK to its principal ally, the BJP.

More women in the fray, but male dominance persists in T.N. polls

From just 11 women candidates in 1967, accounting for 1.41% of the total number of candidates, the figure has risen to 443 in 2026, making up 11.01% of the contestants. Though the increase is notable, proportionally, women continue to occupy only a small share of the candidate pool

Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

The rise in the number of women contesting Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu over the past five decades signals a gradual widening of political participation. However, data show that the gains remain modest when set against the scale of male dominance in the electoral field.

From just 11 women candidates in 1967, accounting for 1.41% of the total, the number has risen to 443 in 2026, which makes up 11.01% of the candidates. The increase is notable in absolute terms, particularly in recent years, but proportionally, women continue to occupy only a small share of the candidate pool.

During the 1970s and 1980s, women's representation hovered below 3%, reflecting limited access to party structures and the broader social barriers that shaped political participation. A shift became visible by the late 1980s and early 1990s, though it was neither sharp nor sustained. By 1991, women constituted 3.6% of the candidates. The most significant depar-

ture came in 1996, when women made up 15.16% of the contestant pool, with 156 of them entering the fray.

Yet, this moment proved to be an outlier. In subsequent elections, the proportion fell back to around 5% to 6%, suggesting that the spike was tied to specific political conditions rather than a structural shift in candidate selection. In the two decades that followed, women's participation remained relatively stagnant even as the total number of contestants increased. The elections in 2001, 2006, and 2011 saw women's representation stay within a narrow range.

A more visible rise has occurred only in the last decade. The 2016 election saw 320 women candidates, or 8.58%, followed by 413 candidates in 2021, pushing the share slightly past 10% for the first time. While this increase points to a gradual opening up of the electoral space, the widening in numbers has not altered the underlying imbalance.

In 2021, male candidates still outnumbered women by nearly nine to one. The expansion of the

Upward trend

Participation of women in Tamil Nadu elections over the years	Year	Total contestants	Women contestants	Women elected
Number of women candidates fielded by major alliances/parties:	1967	778	11	4
	1971	748	15	5
	1977	1,390	24	2
	1980	1,029	17	5
	1984	1,499	46	8
	1989	3,046	78	9
	1991	2,834	102	32
	1996	5,017	156	9
	2001	1,860	112	25
	2006	2,586	156	22
DMK++: 25 (DMK - 19, Congress - 2, VCK - 2, CPI(M) - 1, DMDK - 1)	2011	2,748	143	17
	2016	3,728	320	21
	2021	3,998	413	12
AIADMK++: 28 (AIADMK - 20, BJP - 5, PMK - 3)	2026	4,023	443	N.A.
NTK: 116 women, 1 transwoman				
TVK: 23				

SOURCE: STATISTICAL REPORTS, ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA

overall contestant pool has diluted proportional gains, keeping women's share well below levels that would indicate parity or even substantial representation.

Third gender

There has also been a small but significant development in terms of inclusion beyond the gender binary. Third gender candidates were officially recorded for the first time in 2016, with two contestants, and the same number contested again in 2021. However, in 2026, only one candidate, fielded by the Naam Tami-

lar Katchi, is contesting the poll.

CPI(M) Central Committee Member U. Vasuki said that increasing women's representation in State Assembly politics is unlikely to happen in a meaningful way without a legal mandate. She pointed out that, left to themselves, most political parties continue to field only a small number of women candidates. A law ensuring quotas, she said, would be necessary to move beyond tokenism and bring more women into the electoral arena in a sustained way.

In a recent interview to

West Asia conflict eclipses election talking points among Muslims here

M. Kalyanaraman
RAMANATHAPURAM

Tamil Nadu may be gripped by election fever, but among a cross-section of Muslims in Ramanathapuram, the war in West Asia often overshadows polls in discussions. With kin living in the Persian Gulf, many get daily updates from them.

Iran draws near-universal sympathy here, though the Muslim population is largely not Shia. Chelladurai Abdullah, a Congress leader, says there may be divisions among Muslim countries, but the blame for the war lies squarely with U.S. President Donald Trump.

Pointing to Ramanathapuram's historical links with Iran, Mahamood Naina, a writer and historian from Keelakarai, disputes the perception that Islam came to the region mainly through Arabs. He highlights the role of Persians.

Mr. Naina cites Marco Polo's account of Taki-uddin Abdu-r Rahman, a Persian who served as deputy and minister to a Pandya king, and was granted possession of Fattan (likely Keelakarai), Malifattan, and Kail. He says Taki-uddin's descendants include Vallal Seethakathi of Keelakarai. Referring to Persian historian Wassaf, Mr. Naina adds that Taki-uddin supplied horses to the Madurai king and Malabar through his brother Jama-luddin from Kish Island in Iran, not far from new-smaking Hormuz of today.

He also speaks of Sheikh Syed Mohammed Neyshaburi, a Sufi saint from the Iranian city of Neyshabur, who lived in Keelakarai with his disciples. The



Sizeable base: Nearly one in five residents in Ramanathapuram town are Muslims. FILE PHOTO

14th-century Moroccan traveller, Ibn Battuta, recorded meeting him there. "Persian was known widely here, and the ulema continued to speak it until recently," says Mr. Naina.

Mohideen Thambi, an 81-year-old retired officer of Hindustan Photo Films in Ooty, listens to these accounts and recalls the pre-Islamic Sokkanathar or Meenakshi Sundareswarar temple in Keelakarai. He says his best friend is a Hindu, who has recently become a firm BJP supporter. "I tell him he only has to give up *Bunch Of Thoughts*, RSS leader Golwalkar's book, and everything would be fine," he says.

The elections do find their way into street conversations in Keelakarai, where Muslims form about 80% of the population, according to the 2011 Census. "Most of us will vote for the DMK," says Ahmed Nizar, a retired electrical officer in the merchant navy, seated next to Mr. Thambi.

Keelakarai falls under the Ramanathapuram constituency. The district has about 15% Muslim population, while nearly one in five residents in Ramanathapuram town are Muslims.

At a tea shop, Nawaz, the owner, asks a customer

if he remembers when Keelakarai was an AIADMK bastion. The customer agrees, recalling how the DMK once struggled in local body elections.

That was another era, says Anwhar Raajhaa, a veteran politician, former AIADMK Minister, and Lok Sabha MP. Mr. Chelladurai notes that the AIADMK has fielded only one Muslim candidate this time, at Palayamkottai, which he calls a DMK stronghold.

Mr. Raajhaa recalls MGR's appeal among Muslims, which continued under Jayalalithaa. Mr. Thambi agrees, noting that many women in Keelakarai once voted for the AIADMK.

Voting intentions

Now out of sync with an AIADMK aligned with the BJP, Mr. Raajhaa has joined the DMK. "Muslims with some political maturity, especially older people, will vote for the DMK. Muslim youth may consider voting for (actor-politician) Vijay," he says, adding that Mr. Vijay represents an alternative, and has denied any association with the BJP. "But does he have the character or organisation to sustain it," he asks.

At the tea shop, opinions on Mr. Vijay differ.

Biryani caterers work around fuel shortage for political meetings

Nahla Nainar
TIRUCHI

In Tamil Nadu polls, there's one alliance that is often taken for granted — that of elections and biryani.

The delicacy, which involves the slow cooking of rice in a thick gravy of mutton or chicken, has for long been the staple treat on the election trail in Tamil Nadu.

This year, though, the bond between politics and biryani has been strained by the war in West Asia that has inflated the price of LPG gas cylinders and firewood, hitting mass caterers across the State.

In Tiruchi, as in the rest of Tamil Nadu, meetings have been timed to avoid the summer heat, with most leaders scheduling them in the early hours of the day, or late in the evening, to avoid excessive heat exposure. This has taken away the lunch slot, when party cadres and members of the public attending meetings could expect to be served biryani.

Many biryani caterers in the city said they were not accepting orders from representatives of political parties due to a growing problem with delayed payments.

"The organisers of meetings usually give a token advance of ₹1 lakh to get the biryani ready. But once the work is over, it takes us several months to claim the balance from political parties. We have to pay our staff and meet other expenses. A large banquet order usually has a budget of ₹3 lakh to ₹4 lakh. With the current shortage of fuel and high



Many biryani caterers have stopped taking orders from the organisers of political meetings. R. SELVA MUTHU KUMAR

prices of ingredients, it is easier to cater to social gatherings, because at least the payments are assured," a leading caterer in Tiruchi told *The Hindu*.

Outsourcing orders

Restaurants in Tiruchi have taken to outsourcing biryani orders to master cooks from nearby towns during the election season to lessen the financial burden, as the ingredients are provided by clients.

"For now, those who attend political gatherings from remote villages are given free parcels of biryani. Chicken biryani is preferred, since it is cheaper than mutton biryani. We use the *Thulasi* variety of short-to-medium grain rice, which is more affordable than *Basmati* or *Jee-raga Samba*," said Khaja Mohideen, a long-time biryani caterer based out of Thanjavur.

"Our real business is on election day, when parties arrange for biryani parcels in bulk. We have cooked for up to 6,000 people, with 750 kg of chicken and 600 kg of rice, at recent political meetings," he added.

INBRIEF



Two ophthalmologists win awards for educational films

Two ophthalmologists from Dr. Agarwals Eye Hospitals have been honoured with international awards at the 44th Film Festival of the American Society of Cataract and Refractive Surgery (ASCRS) held in Washington D.C., U.S., for their educational films on advanced eye surgical techniques. Athiya Agarwal, Director, Dr. Agarwals Eye Hospital, won the first prize for her submission, “Pearls of Iris Repair”, which highlights the ‘Pinhole Pupilloplasty’, an iris repair technique that improves visual quality by allowing only the central light rays into the eye. In the same film festival, Soosan Jacob, Director and Chief of Dr. Agarwals Refractive and Cornea Foundation, won the runner-up award for her surgical video presentation titled, “Rebubbling in Keratoplasty”, which focuses on the role of rebubbling, a procedure that helps a transplanted corneal layer adhere properly after surgeries.



Kia creates exclusive parking at Rajinikanth's tribute event

Over 3,500 people attended the Rajinikanth tribute event, “The Badass Concert”, held in Chennai. Kia created dedicated priority parking zones exclusively for Kia owners at the concert, recognising the challenge faced by attendees at such large-scale events, including parking chaos and exit congestion, according to a press release. All Kia customers were given reserved parking spaces, and priority exit post the event. This allowed them to avoid long queues and traffic bottlenecks, said a release.

Two held for sexual assault on minor boys

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Mambalam police arrested a 27-year-old man and a juvenile under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act for committing sexual assault on minor boys. The police said two

boys, aged 13 and 10, were subjected to sexual assault by the accused, who showed them pornographic videos and coerced them into enacting the acts depicted in it. The accused threatened to kill them, holding a knife to their throats, if they revealed the abuse to their family members.

The issue came to light after a police team inquired about a fight between the two juvenile boys in the neighbourhood. During interrogation, one of the boys exposed the assault they were subjected to at the accused's house. The West Mambalam police registered a case un-

der the POCSO Act and arrested the 27-year-old man. He was produced before a magistrate's court and remanded in judicial custody at the Central Prison in Puzhal. The juvenile was produced before the Juvenile Justice Board and later sent to the Government Observation Home for boys in Kellys.

HC dismisses Tamannaah's plea for damages from Power Soaps

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Thursday dismissed a case filed by film actor Tamannaah Santhosh Bhatia seeking damages of ₹1 crore from Puducherry-based Power Soaps Limited for having allegedly continued to use her photographs on soap wrappers and promotional materials even after the expiry of the agreement for being its brand ambassador.

A Division Bench of Justices P. Velmurugan and K. Govindarajan Thilakavadi rejected an original side appeal filed by Ms. Bhatia in 2018 challenging the dismissal of her 2011 civil suit by a single judge of the High Court on April 17, 2017. The Bench did not find any reason to interfere with dismissal of the civil suit, with costs, by Justice T. Ravindran (since retired from service). In her 2011 plaint, Ms. Bhatia, said Power Soaps had approached her in



Tamannaah Bhatia

2008 to be the product's brand ambassador. An agreement was signed between them on October 7, 2008. Thereafter, the plaintiff participated in the photo shoot, and the business of the company had increased manifold after that. Though Power Soaps was interested in extending the agreement beyond October 6, 2009, she refused to do so, the actor claimed. In 2010, when Ms. Bhatia was holding negotiations with Wipro for promoting their soaps, it came to her notice that Power Soaps was continuing to use her videos and photographs even after the expiry of the agreement. The

refore, she instituted the suit in 2011, claiming damages of ₹1 crore by accusing Power Soaps of having exploited her popularity unlawfully. Power Soaps denied all the allegations, and said that the actor was not popular when the agreement was reached in 2008. The company said she was paid only ₹1 lakh for the one-year contract and denied the claim that its business had increased manifold because of her. The firm also asserted it had stopped using her photographs after the expiry of the agreement. After hearing both sides, the single judge had held that the actor failed to produce incontrovertible material in support of her case. “The plaintiff has come forward with the present suit on the basis of unreliable and unacceptable materials and accordingly, unable to establish her case for obtaining the reliefs sought for,” Justice Ravindran had said, leading to the present appeal.

T.N. ELECTIONS 2026

Saptarshi Bhattacharya
CHENNAI

The Higher Education Department in Tamil Nadu had been a virtual battleground of an ideological war between the DMK and the BJP at the Centre, over the past five years. The result has not been pretty. Whether it is the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) for admission to undergraduate and postgraduate medical courses, or the appointment of vice-chancellors to State-run universities, this ideological battle has taken a toll on efforts to keep up the quality of higher education delivered to students in the State.

Over a dozen public universities in Tamil Nadu have been functioning without vice-chancellors for nearly two years due to a tussle between the Governor and the State government. Also, the State Assembly had passed a Bill to abolish NEET twice, and twice it was rejected.

Soon after coming to power, the DMK government in September 2021 passed a Bill in the Assembly which sought to dispense with the requirement for candidates to qualify in NEET exam for admission to UG and PG medical courses in the State. NEET, the Bill stated, festered inequality as it favoured the privileged class



Long battle: The State Assembly passed a Bill to abolish the NEET twice, and it was rejected by the Governor both the times . FILE PHOTO

of society who could afford special coaching for the exam. The Bill said that its aim was to ensure social justice, uphold equality and equal opportunity, and protect vulnerable students communities from discrimination.

The move followed a report from a high-level committee headed by Justice A.K. Rajan, retired High Court judge.

The Assembly re-adopted the Bill the following year after Presidential assent was declined. In 2025, assent was declined yet again leaving the State government with barely any option. An all-party meeting chaired by Chief Minister M.K. Stalin soon after this unanimously resolved to pursue legal options.

The opposition to NEET became an emotive issue in Tamil Nadu after S. Anitha of Ariyalur, died by suicide in 2017 for not having qualified in the en-

trance exam. She scored 1176/1200 in her HSC examination, which could have secured her a medical seat in the earlier system. She had impleaded herself as a respondent in a Supreme Court case challenging NEET.

Ideological battle

A tumultuous extension of this ideological battle played out between the Governor, R.N. Ravi, and the government headed by Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on several issues, the most important being appointment of vice-chancellors to public universities.

The conflict reached a flashpoint when the Tamil Nadu government approached the Supreme Court against Governor Ravi for withholding about Bills passed by the Assembly, including a 2022 Bill that transferred the power of appointing vice-chancellors from the Governor to

the State government.

This Bill, incidentally, was also challenged in the Madras High Court which stayed the amendments. However, earlier this year, the Supreme Court set aside the injunction, remitted the matter back to the High Court and fixed a six-week deadline for a decision.

While the hearing goes on, 16 of the 22 State-run universities continue to stagger through without institutional heads. This has led to several bottlenecks in the running of these universities, including recruitment of faculty.

With barely any solution in sight to these face-offs, the new government will have its task cut out.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State's health helpline 104, TeleMANAS 14416, and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050).



Dip in stock: A dealer says fuel outlets were going dry due to high volume of sales. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

LPG autorickshaws wait in queues as fuel outlets go dry

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Retail outlets selling auto liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) in and around the city have been witnessing long queues for the past few days. “Private bunks selling LPG are mostly closed and those have stocks are selling it close to ₹100 a kg, which is not affordable for me,” said Vijay Karthick, an autorickshaw driver.

Several bunks, including those at Injambakkam, Kilpauk, Vyasarpadi, and Avadi, belonging to State-run oil marketing companies (OMCs) are the ones seeing such queues, said sources in the oil industry.

A dealer said that some bunks belonging to OMCs were going dry due to high volume of sales. “I usually buy one load, selling around 1500 kg to 2000 kg

a day. But now, with increased demand, I am selling almost 5,000 kg a day. Though LPG availability is not an issue for me, making the payment and getting the load takes a whole day when the bunk goes dry. The police is not allowing heavy vehicles during certain hours, which also leads to bunks going dry.”

Balasubramanian of the CITU Auto Thozhilalargar Sammelanam said that the government must ensure availability of auto LPG in all bunks. “There are 40,000 families dependent on LPG. They are able to get LPG only once in two days. They have to wait in queue for six hours just to fill for ₹400 to ₹500. The whole day gets wasted waiting for fuel at OMC outlets, since private gas is priced at ₹100 a kg. OMCs sell gas at ₹84.35 a kg,” he said.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

HOMAGE



We deeply grieve the demise of our Founder & Chairman
Dr. P. Padmanabhan, M.D.
City Tower Hospitals, Chennai on 04.04.2026

Rituals will be held at his residence
on 18.04.2026 6 pm & 19.04.2026 10 am - 12 Noon
#15, Collectorate Colony Main Road, Aminjikarai,
Chennai - 600 029. Mob: 98403 24229

DEATH

HOMAGE



CREATIVE CHEENA

Mentor in Theatre
Passed away on 16.4.2026
வாழ்க ந ினா
தவயகம் கடந்தும் வாழியவே
TV Varadharajan &
Univ Visuals Family

DEATH

RESPECTFUL HOMAGE



DOB: JULY 16, 1926 | DOD: APRIL 16, 2026
Sri. S. CHIDAMBARAM IYER
(RETD, D.Y.C.E.E. I.C.F)
Wife - Late R. Nagalakshmi, Son-Late Ranganathan
Deeply mourned by
Smt. Sarathi (Sister)
Abhisha Srinivasan & Poroma Rajan (Daughters)
Srinivasan & Venkat Rajan (Son in Law)
Anun Prashant & Arjuna (Grandson And Grand Daughters)
Shruti & Venkat (Grand Daughter And Grand Son in Law)
Kusum & Sulochana (Caregivers)

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES
To dedicate a space in this section, Please contact:
044-28576300
from 10.00 a.m. to 6.00 p.m.
Toll Free 1800 102 4161
from 10.00 a.m. to 10.00 p.m.
For Placing Advertisements Online
log on to
www.thehinduads.com
DONATE EYES GIFT SIGHT

Timing CHENNAI			
FRIDAY, APR. 17			
RISE	05:56	SET	18:22
RISE	05:29	SET	18:18
SATURDAY, APR. 18			
RISE	05:55	SET	18:22
RISE	06:15	SET	19:20
SUNDAY, APR. 19			
RISE	05:55	SET	18:22
RISE	07:07	SET	20:25

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	38	24
Chennai Airport	37	27
Chennai City	34	27

Chennai Airport Today
37°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night also will be comfortable. Dry weather to occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
37°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm. Night will be comfortable.

© Copyright Skymet Weather 2026
All rights reserved.

THE HINDU
DISCLAIMER: Readers are requested to verify and make appropriate enquires to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THE PUBLISHING PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

Tamil Nadu InFocus

THE HINDU

NUGGETS OF HISTORY

South India's oldest hydroelectric project was launched in 1932

The Pykara Hydroelectric Project in the Nilgiris is one of South India's oldest hydropower projects. Its aim was to tap into the power generation potential of River Pykara, which originates in the Western Ghats. Commissioned in 1932, it was conceived with three units of a total capacity of 6.65 MW.

Soviet Cultural Centre started Tal Chess Club in Chennai in 1972

Chennai's association with chess started in the 1970s. The Soviet Cultural Centre established the Tal Chess Club in 1972. India's first International Master Manuel Aaron played an instrumental role in the club. It became the ultimate incubator for local talent, famously producing India's first Grandmaster Viswanathan Anand.

M. Vasanthakumari appointed the first woman bus driver

M. Vasanthakumari, who hailed from Kanniyakumari district, was the first woman to be appointed a bus driver in the Tamil Nadu State Transport Corporation. In 1993, she received the appointment order from the then Chief Minister, Jayalalithaa. After serving the corporation for nearly 24 years, she retired in 2017.

Valparai Plateau in the Western Ghats is a crucial wildlife habitat

Valparai Plateau, part of the Western Ghats, is an ecologically significant zone. It is known for tea and coffee plantations and is a crucial habitat for wildlife, especially for elephant migration. During the annual migration season, elephants migrate from Kerala to the Valparai Plateau, which is also part of the Anamalai Tiger Reserve.

A titan of number theory, who proved Waring's Problem

While Ramanujan is globally celebrated, another mathematician from Tamil Nadu, S.S. Pillai of Tirunelveli, was a titan of number theory. In the 1930s, he proved the conundrum known as Waring's Problem. He died in a plane crash while travelling to the Institute for Advanced Study, Princeton. *(Compiled by N. Sai Charan)*

The freedom fighter who fought against Kala Paani after being convicted in Salem riots case

Salem C. Vijiaraghavachariar, one of the doyens of the national movement during the pre-Gandhi era and the first Tamil to become the All India Congress Committee president, was ordered to be transported to Andamans to serve a 10-year imprisonment. He appealed to the High Court of Madras and got his conviction quashed on January 9, 1883

T. Ramakrishnan

Andamans, notoriously called Kala Paani (black water) during colonial rule, served as a penal settlement from the second half of the 19th Century, even before the construction of the Cellular Jail during 1896-1906. Many freedom fighters, including Vaman Rao Joshi, Sohan Singh, Vinayak Damodar Savarkar, Bhai Parmanand, and Nand Gopal had been kept at the jail. What is less known is a prominent Congress leader from Tamil Nadu, Salem C. Vijiaraghavachariar (1852-1944), was ordered to be transported there to serve a 10-year imprisonment. He got it legally rescinded. He was implicated in a case concerning the Salem Hindu-Muslim riots in August 1882 and convicted three months later. “Though thirty and facing many privations, Mr. Vijiaraghavachariar was not daunted by the sentence. He appealed to the High Court of Madras and succeeded in getting his conviction quashed on January 9, 1883, much to the chagrin of the local bureaucrats who had counted on silencing the independent young lawyer,” wrote *The Hindu* in its obituary on him on April 21, 1944. The report said, “He did not rest with vindicating himself gloriously, but fought for the next two years to get the other accused also released.”

Removed from Municipal Council Vijiaraghavachariar was the first Tamil to become the president of the All India Congress Committee (AICC) at the Nagpur session in 1920. His 82nd death anniversary falls on April 19. His rebellious spirit came to the fore again when the British government removed him from the Salem Municipal Council on the ground that he was “an undesirable person”. He challenged the decision in the High Court and sought damages. He won, and was awarded token damages of ₹100. In his battle against the official establishment, he received enthusiastic support from newspapers



Courage undaunted: The statue of C. Vijiaraghavachariar at his memorial library in Salem. E. LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

such as *The Hindu* and the *Amrita Bazar Patrika*. When he died, C. Rajagopalachari (CR or Rajaji), who was junior, recalled the advice of Vijiaraghavachariar to illustrate how sturdily independent his senior was: It was the duty of all practitioners at the Bar not merely to carry on their profession but also to take part in public life and “to stand up for the defence” of people against “any inroads” of the authorities. Though the term ‘Salem’ became a prefix for him, Vijiaraghavachariar was born at Pon Vilaindha Kalathur near Chengalpattu. His father Sadagopachariar, deeply versed in Sanskrit, wanted his son to follow in his footsteps, but the boy, who mastered the Vedas in his early days, had his own plans. The passion for English was so great that he fled home and took shelter at his

uncle's house in Madurantakam, according to the material provided by his great-grandson P. Srinivasan, who is the president of a museum-library named after the former Congress president. Academically brilliant, Vijiaraghavachariar went on to do his graduation at Presidency College, Madras. While working briefly as lecturer at a government college in Mangaluru, he quit in protest against the racial prejudice of the European principal. It was then that he came to Salem and privately qualified for the Bar. The legal successes he had achieved in the Salem riots case shot him to national fame. He was hailed as the ‘Hero of Salem’ and the ‘Lion of South India’. Soon, he became a member of the committee that drafted the constitution of the Congress. When the organisation split between “moderates” and “extremists” over the concepts of *swaraj* (self-government) and national education and the former took control of the party, he stayed away from the organisational activity as he sided with Bal Gangadhar Tilak. He again began playing a dominant role after the 1916 resolution when a unified Congress came into being and Mahatma Gandhi had then entered the arena. When the party focussed on issues such as the Jallianwala Bagh massacre and the Khilafat Movement, Vijiaraghavachariar convinced Gandhiji to go beyond these issues and demand “*swaraj*”. At the Nagpur session chaired by him in 1920, the party decided to intensify its efforts as Gandhiji's historic resolution on non-cooperation was adopted. When Lord Birkenhead was the Secretary of State for India in the mid-1920s and threw down a challenge whether Indians could draw up a Constitution for themselves, he, as a member of the Motilal Nehru's panel, played a crucial role in drawing up, what is even now called, the Swaraj Constitution, says the Congress's website. His interest in social reforms was no less significant. He advocated post-puberty marriage for women and also the right of a daughter to

have a share in her father's property. He advocated the much-needed change in the Hindu personal law at a time when any talk about it was a taboo, says the Congress's website. A paper presented by academic R. Kumaran at the 2012 conference of the South Indian History Congress notes that at the third session of the Congress in 1887, he emphasised the need for social reconstruction and the upliftment of religious and communal minorities, besides appealing to Muslims to join the Congress in larger numbers. He carried on an anti-untouchability campaign. He condemned racial discrimination and sponsored the claims of the labour. He spurned titles and resisted the lure of office. **‘Pioneer of fundamental rights’** On a piece of land gifted by the Salem local body, the C. Vijiaraghavachariar Memorial Library-Public Hall has been functioning since July 1951. The then Chief Minister, P.S. Kumaraswami Raja, declared it open, whereas his predecessor T. Prakasam laid the foundation in August 1950. The city has two statues for him – one on the premises of the library and the other on the busy Second Aghraharam. While the first was unveiled by former Union Finance Minister R. Venkataraman in 1982, the second was by M.G. Ramachandran two years later. Venkataraman hailed him as the pioneer of fundamental rights. Vijiaraghavachariar's grandson R.T. Parthasarathy, an associate of former Chief Minister K. Kamaraj, served as a Member of the Rajya Sabha during 1966-72. Dr. Srinivasan rues that the authorities, in 2023, had acquired a portion of the library land, measuring about 310 square metres, for an infrastructure project without paying a fair compensation, unlike what they did a year earlier, when a smaller portion of the property was taken over. His point is that the authorities should not do anything that would belittle an institution that seeks to perpetuate the memory of a brave fighter with its modest means.

How Scheduled Castes empowered themselves by establishing schools

The community established schools not only in Tirunelveli district but also in other parts of Tamil Nadu. Now, there are 28 schools originally established by the community that are functioning as government-aided primary schools in Tirunelveli

Bhagavathi Sampath K. J.

In 1924, at a Gurukulam established by V. V. S. Iyer at Cheranmahadevi, Tirunelveli, Brahmin and non-Brahmin students were made to dine separately. This caste discrimination at a Gurukulam played a pivotal role in Tamil Nadu's politics, with Periyar E. V. Ramasamy leaving the Congress and forming the Dravidar Kazhagam. At a time when this incident shook civil society, the Soosaiappan Primary School on Arasadi Street at Cheranmahadevi, which had completed 50 years, stood out as a shining example of empowerment of the Scheduled Castes (SCs) through education. Students from other castes studied at the school too. The school was founded in 1874 by a prominent Catholic elder from the community without any assistance from Christian missionaries. It now functions as a government-aided primary school.

State-wide drive The efforts of the SCs in establishing schools were not confined to Tirunelveli district. To empower the community, the community leaders launched similar schools across the State. These institutions were identified as Adi Dravida, long before the term ‘Dalit’ gained currency. Now, there are 28 schools established by the SCs that are functioning as government-aided primary schools in Tirunelveli. J. Balasubramaniam, Assistant Professor, Department of Journalism, Madurai Kamaraj



Symbol of determination: Hindu Adi Dravidar Primary School at Thalavaipuram.

University, has studied these schools in Tirunelveli. “It is widely believed that efforts to empower the Dalits through education were led mainly by the British, Christian missionaries, and reform organisations,” he said. Though there is a prevailing notion that the SCs lacked the resources to build institutions, these schools stood testimony to the role of the community in promoting education and social uplift, he said. In the 1880s, many members of the community migrated from Thiruppanikarisalkulam in Tirunelveli to Colombo (Sri Lanka) where they ran tailoring

shops and textile stores and worked as butlers.

School in a hut

Youngsters who returned from Colombo formed the Thiruppanikarisalkulam Youth Association and started a school in a hut in 1885 by appointing a teacher. They collected funds from members of the community in the village and those in Colombo and paid the teacher's salary. The school received government recognition as a single-teacher aided school in 1924. Until a panchayat union primary school was established in the village in the 1980s, all sections studied at this school. In 1955, 435 students, including 170 girls, were enrolled at the school. Now, it functions with 45 students and four teachers. “Although these schools were established by the Dalit community, they acted as public schools, open to everyone and were highly inclusive,” said Mr. Balasubramaniam. S.S. Periyasamy and Ponnusamy were among the SCs who had worked in Colombo and thereafter became involved in the Adi Dravidar politics and empowerment. They established Adi Dravida schools at Thalavaipuram and Keezha Pappakudi respectively. The school at Keezha Pappakudi is no longer functional. They wrote in the *Adidravidan* journal, published from Colombo, stressing the importance of education as a means of social uplift. They also wrote against caste discrimination. Similarly, R.S. Arumugam, a prominent Congress leader, was instrumental in establishing schools in Tirunelveli district. He held

responsibilities at the district and State levels in the Harijan Sevak Sangh. It is also important to recognise the role of mutts in the education of the SCs. Despite the prevalence of untouchability, the SCs were not entirely excluded from these institutions. Both Periyasamy and Ponnusamy were in touch with Swami Sahajananda, a SC spiritual leader, who established Nandanar Educational Trust and Mutt in Chidambaram for educating children of the depressed classes in 1916. In fact, the Thalavaipuram Adi Dravidar School, established by Ponnusamy in Tirunelveli, was initially started under the name, Om Nandanar School, after the Nandanar trust and mutt. Om Prakash Swami, who established the Dakshinamurthy Mutt in Udthagamandalam, was instrumental in the uplift of the SCs through education. In Tirunelveli's Pappiahpuram, the community established a school named after Om Prakash Swami. **Names changed in line with times** Mr. Balasubramaniam said the names of the schools changed over the years – Adi Dravida, Harijan, Ambedkar – to get government aid and reflect the political climate of the time. The schools adopted the term ‘Harijan’ when it was promoted by Mahatma Gandhi. Later, the community considered the term derogatory and removed it. They also renamed some schools after B. R. Ambedkar. According to Mr. Balasubramaniam, emergence of English medium schools was a major reason for these institutions to lose their importance. “Caste Hindus, who were appointed managers, appropriated them after they became aided schools. Once under the independent administration of the Dalits, these schools were transferred to the control of the Adi Dravidar Welfare Department.” M. Veldurai, an anaesthesiologist, studied till class 5 at Vivekananda Primary School, an Adi Dravidar school started at Vellanguli in 1923. He is its treasurer. It now functions with 100 students and four teachers. He said these schools would stay relevant only if they were made English-medium schools with more infrastructure.

Thanjavur Big Temple inscriptions bring alive the fierce fight between Shivaji and Afzal Khan

The inscriptions, written in Marathi on the south-western walls near the Vinayagar Temple, also describe the history of the Maratha kings and praise Danish missionary Rev. Christian Frederick Schwarz. They also highlight how Serfoji sent his army and offered financial assistance to the British during the war against the Marudu brothers

B. Kolappan

Among the many inscriptions in the Thanjavur Big Temple, a marvellous creation of the imperial Cholas, the largest record dates to the Maratha period. These inscriptions, which trace the genealogy of the Bhonsala family of Thanjavur, narrate a story that unfolds like a thriller. *Bhonsala Vamsa Charitra*, published by the Sarasvati Mahal Library, vividly recounts the encounter between Chhatrapati Shivaji, wearing tiger-claws, and Afzal Khan, one of the most gripping episodes in history. “The inscriptions are found on the south-western walls near the Vinayagar Temple. Written in Marathi, this is the largest inscription of Serfoji II. It describes the history of the Maratha kings and also contains praise for the Danish missionary, Rev. Christian Frederick Schwarz. The account further records how Serfoji sent his army and offered financial assistance to the British during the war against the Marudu brothers,” M. Nalini writes in her book *Rajarajisvaram*. V. Srinivasachari and S. Gopalan, editors of *Bhonsala Vamsa Charitra*, have documented the entire history in Marathi and Tamil, besides presenting a brief version in English. Through the book, not only does the confrontation between Shivaji and Afzal Khan – a general of the Adil Shahi dynasty of the Bijapur Sultanate – unfold vividly before the reader but also the events that followed Afzal Khan’s death. Krishnaji Pant, a Brahmin and minister of Afzal Khan, continued the fight with Shivaji after the fall of his master.

‘Celebrated victory’

However, according to *Bhonsala Vamsa Charitra*, this celebrated victory of Shivaji was achieved through the blessings of Sree Jagathambika Tulja Bhavani, the tutelary deity of the royal family. She is said to have appeared in Shivaji’s dream, advising him to leave Pune for the fort at Jawali to outmanoeuvre Afzal Khan. The deity is believed to have told him, “I shall bring about the *samhara* [killing] of Afzal Khan through you there itself.” Shivaji left for the Jawali Fort after

strengthening the forts in the Pune region. He sent secret messages to the fort commanders, instructing them to allow Afzal Khan’s forces passage towards Jawali. “I will meet him on the grounds of the Jawali Fort. If the agreement is broken, we shall beat the *nagara* [drum]. At that signal, all your forces must surround his men, prevent them from entering the fort, and kill the enemies wherever you find them,” he said. When Afzal Khan learnt that Shivaji had reached the Jawali Fort, he sent a letter through Krishnaji Pant. In the letter, he accused Shivaji of capturing Adil Shahi forts, killing his generals, looting his treasures, denigrating Islam, demolishing mosques, and seating himself on a throne adorned with precious gems. However, he expressed his willingness to make concessions on account of Shivaji’s father

Bhonsala Vamsa Charitra, published by the Sarasvati Mahal Library, vividly recounts the encounter between Chhatrapati Shivaji, wearing tiger-claws, and Afzal Khan, one of the most gripping episodes in history.

Shahaji being a friend of the Sultan. In return, Shivaji was asked to hand over the forts under his control and return to Poona. Afzal Khan added that any settlement reached would be conveyed to the Sultan. Shivaji received Krishnaji Pant and suggested that he meet Afzal Khan at the Jawali Fort for talks. On receiving this message, Afzal Khan,

despite warnings from his ministers about Shivaji’s alleged deceit, set out eagerly to meet him. “There were ill omens, but Afzal Khan paid no heed to them. He reached the Jawali Fort and sent a message to Shivaji,” the book records. Before the meeting took place, Shivaji was informed that Afzal Khan, after leaving Vijapur, had plundered territories under his control and killed his elder brother Sambhaji. His father Shahaji is said to have performed the final rites and later died in grief. Afzal Khan arrived in a palanquin in the company of Krishnaji Pant and some bodyguards. Shivaji met him with a few bodyguards. Even as the talks were in progress, Afzal Khan embraced Shivaji and held him tight before stabbing him with a knife. Since Shivaji was wearing an iron jacket, he escaped the attack. Then he attacked Afzal Khan with his tiger-claws and tore apart his stomach, releasing his entrails. A terrified Afzal Khan covered his stomach with a blanket and fought Shivaji. Dodging his attacks with his dagger, Shivaji made a cut on the top of Afzal Khan’s left arm, drawing the dagger down to the lower side of the other arm. He fell unconscious and died on a Thursday in 1581, corresponding with *Vihari Varudum*.

Offer of help

The fight did not end with Afzal Khan’s death. Krishnaji Pant picked up Afzal Khan’s sword and started fighting with Shivaji. “You are a Brahmin. My *dharma* will not allow me to kill you. We worship Brahmins, since they are our gurus and have a status on a par with the Devas. You may leave this place by dropping your knife. I will open the roads for you. If you prefer to stay here, I will provide you with food and clothing,” the inscriptions recall Shivaji as telling Krishnaji Pant. Though he continued his attack, Shivaji began to withdraw without retaliating. A bodyguard, however, struck back, convincing himself that saving the king was paramount. Krishnaji died. “The *nagara* was sounded, and the Maratha warriors killed the soldiers of Afzal Khan waiting outside. Shivaji treated the captured soldiers with honour and allowed them to go free,” say the inscriptions.



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

THE HINDU
Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-;
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-Open Tender Notice
E-Tender Notice No.: CRW-HRT-M-LUC-MISC-OT-26, Date: 11/04/2026
For and on behalf of President of India, Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut invites open e-tender for the following works as detailed:-
1. Name of work with its location : Loading, Unloading & Cleaning in Wheel shop and Bogie shop and Miscellaneous work in Heavy Repair Shop & Air Brake Shop as per scope of work at CRW/Harnaut, Nalanda, Bihar”. 2. Approx. cost of the work : ₹ 6,07,33,111.91 (Rupees Six Crore Seven Lakh Thirty Three Thousand One Hundred Eleven and Ninety One Paise only). 3. Cost of Tender Form : NIL 4. Earnest Money to be deposited : ₹154,41,27,136.20/- (Rs. Twelve Lakh Fourteen Thousand Seven Hundred only). 5. Date & Time for submission of tender and opening of Tender : The tender have to be submitted online on <https://www.ireps.gov.in> website up to 12:00 hrs. on 02.05.2026 and will be opened on the same day at 12:30 hrs. 6. Website particulars, Notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.: Detailed tender notice, eligibility criteria & tender documents can be seen from the CRIS website: <https://www.ireps.gov.in> & full details of notice can be seen on notice board in the office of Chief Workshop Manager, Administrative Building, Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut, Nalanda, Bihar - 803110. All corrigendum if any, will be uploaded on website, if required.
Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer
Carriage Repair Workshop/Harnaut
PR/061/CRW-HRT/CRW/T-26-27/48

RFP FOR CONSTRUCTION WORKS
E-Tender Notice No. CON/2026/ APR/01 Dated: 07-04-2026. Open tender through e-Tendering system is invited from experienced and reputed contractor(s)/firm(s) for the following works: **Tender No. CE/CON/KJG/EP/2026/03. Name of work:** RFP for Earthwork in formation and in cutting, blanketing, construction of RCC box, RCC and PCC drains, retaining walls, toe walls, nine (9) numbers minor bridges, one (1) number Road Over Bridge (ROB), Railway Electrification works including design, supply, erection, testing and commissioning of OHE, Electrical (General) works and Signalling and Telecom works from Kokrajhar station (excluding) to CH-4.100 and from Salakati station (excluding) to CH-0.400 in connection with the construction of the New Railway Line between Kokrajhar and Gelephu on Hybrid-EPC mode. Approx. value: ₹154,41,27,136.20/- **Date & Time of closing of tender: 14.30 hrs. on 20-05-2026 & opening at: 15.30 hrs. on 26-05-2026.** The complete information and tender document of above e-Tender will be available at www.ireps.gov.in
Chief Engineer/CON/ Meghalaya Project/Mailgaon
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY (Construction Organisation)
Serving Customers With A Smile

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-Open Tender Notice
For and or behalf of the India invited e-open tender (E-Tender Notice no - cw-sonpur-05-2026) from experienced contractor for the work given below:-
(1) **Name of the work with its location:** Provision for the work of Outsourcing of various activities which include welding, door repair and replacement, EM Pad change, Adaptor change at Ganara Freight Depot for 02 years. (2) **Approx. cost of the work:** Rs. 3,40,54,688.30/- (Rs. Three Cr. Forty lakh Fifty-Four thousand Six Hundred Eighty-Eight and Thirty paise only) (3) **Earnest Money to be deposited:** Rs. 6,81,100,00/- (Six Lakh Eighty-One Thousand One Hundred only) (4) **Date & time for submission of tender and opening of tender:** Tender submission date & time: Up to 15.00 Hrs. dated 04-05-2026 Opening date & time: After 15.00 Hrs. on dated 04-05-2026 (5) **Website particulars notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.:** Website: <https://www.ireps.gov.in>. Railway administration reserves the right to postpone/ modify or to cancel the tender any time without assigning any reasons. **ADME/C&W/SEE PR/0071/SEE/C&W/T/26-27/36**

SOUTHERN RAILWAY
(Electrical (General), Construction, Egmore, Chennai)
Tender Notice No.E-HQ-CN-MS-EOT-02&03-2026-27 dt.10/04/2026 &13/04/2026.
For and on behalf of the President of India, The Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer / General / Construction / Southern Railway / Egmore, Chennai - 600008 invites E-Tender for the following Work,
Name of Work:
1. Provision of Industrial Air-Conditioning System in Relay Room/El Cabins/ Huts at Various Locations of Arakkonam Junction.
2. Electrification and power supply arrangements for station buildings, Platforms, LC gate lodges, S&T Huts, Pumping arrangements, Electrification of Camp Office, Railway Staff Quarters etc in Tindivanam Nagari - Sholinganaur - Walajah Road section Reach 4 @ Kodakkal (H) & Sholinghur Town - Works Contract
Tender Notice No. and Date
E-HQ-CN-MS-EOT-02 -2026-27 Dt.10.04.2026
E-HQ-CN-MS-EOT-03 -2026-27 Dt.13.04.2026
Period of Completion 3 Months 4 Months
Approximate Cost of Work ₹47,93,765.64/- ₹74,48,330.52/-
Cost of Tender form Nil Nil
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) ₹95,900/- ₹1,49,000/-
Tender Closing Date & Time 06/05/2026 at 11.00AM, 11/05/2026 at 11.00AM,
Tender Opening Date & Time 06/05/2026 at 11.30AM, 11/05/2026 at 11.30AM.
Complete details can be seen on www.ireps.gov.in.
Dy. Chief Elec. Engineer/Gen./Cons./ S.Rly, Egmore, Chennai-8

Your feedback will keep us Cleaner, Sharper and Bolder

Call our toll-free number
1800 102 1878
Or write to us at
customercare@thehindu.co.in

Scan the QR code to register your feedback

THE HINDU thehindu **businessline.**
FRONTLINE SPORTSTAR THE HINDU WORLD THE HINDU

Metro Railway, Kolkata
Notice for E-Auction Sale
E-Auction sale for disposal of Released and Scrap Materials of Metro Railway, Kolkata will be held on 24.04.2026, 20.05.2026 & 17.06.2026.
Principal Chief Materials Manager
Follow us at: metrorailwaykol metrorailkolkata

भारतीय भूचुंबकत्व संस्थान, मुंबई
Indian Institute of Geomagnetism, Mumbai
(विज्ञान एवं प्रौद्योगिकी विभाग भारत सरकार के अधीन एक स्वायत्त निकाय)
(An Autonomous Body under Dept. of Science & Technology, Government of India)
Advt. No. 02/IIG/HRD/2026 Dated: April 15, 2026
IIG Mumbai invites online applications for admission to Integrated MS(R)-PhD Program in Physics (Space Physics) 2026. For detailed advertisement, please visit: <https://iigm.res.in/admissions/integrated-msr-ph-d>
CBC 36127/12/0002/2627 Registrar

Executive Engineer Office,
P. W. Division No. 1, Thane Parking Plaza
Building 8th Floor, Service Road,
Off Eastern Express Highway,
Near Jupiter Hospital, Thane - 400601
www.mahapwd.com thane1.ee@mahapwd.gov.in 25369293
No./TD/Tender/4150 Date: 13/04/2026
E-Tender Corrigendum No.1 (Time Table)
WORK NAME:- E-Tender No.55/01 Year 2025-26 Tender ID:- 2026_PWR_1292018_1 Construction Of 900 Bedded District Civil, And Super Specialty Hospital, Building Nursing Training Centre and Hostel Building at Civil Hospitals Complex, Thane, Tal. Dist. Thane (Providing, Supplying and Fixing Furniture, Furniture Layout Audio and Video Systems for Auditorium Hall).
Estimated Cost:- **₹ 51,60,28,289.00**
Ref:- E-Tender Notice No. 55 Year 2025-26 letter Dated No. This Office Letter No. Tender/3676 Date. 25/03/2026.

Sr. No	Tender	Before Publish Date	Now Publish Date
1	Selling Date	01.04.2026 to 17.04.2026	01.04.2026 to 22.04.2026
2	Pre-bid Mitting	07.04.2026	-
3	Tender Opening Date	20.04.2026	23.04.2026

Sd/-
Executive Engineer,
P. W. Division No. 1, Thane

DGIPR/2026-2027/227

GOVERNMENT OF KARNATAKA
KARNATAKA SLUM DEVELOPMENT BOARD
No. 55, Abhaya Complex, Risaldar Street, Seshadripuram, BENGALURU-560 020. Ph:-080-23460085
No: KSDB/Commr/CE/Mandya- RAY/2026-27 Dated:31/03/2026
INVITATION FOR TENDER (IFT)
(THROUGH KPP PORTAL MODE ONLY) (TWO COVER SYSTEM)
The Karnataka Slum Development Board (KSDB), Bengaluru invites lumpsum tenders through KPP Portal for **Construction of 127(G+1) Dus at HalahallySy.no,14 & 16 and behind Kalikamba temple on DBT Basis in Mandya City under RAY scheme** from eligible Registered Class I and above Contractors.

Calendar of Events	
Date and Time for Pre-Bid Conference	21.04.2026 at 11:00 AM
Last date and time for receipt of Tender Documents	02.05.2026at 05:30 PM
Time and Date of Opening of Tender Documents (Qualification Information)	04.05.2026 at 11:00 AM
Place of Receiving and Opening of Tender Documents	Office of the Chief Engineer, Karnataka Slum Development Board, #55, 1st Floor Abhaya Complex, Risaldar Street Sheshadripuram, Bengaluru-560020. Phone: +91-80-23564651, 23462436. Email.id: Ksdbce@gmail.com Website :https://ksdb. karnataka.gov.in
Time and Date of Opening of Financial Bid	Time and Date will be Intimated for the eligible bidders

If there are any changes to the above notification, it will be published in e-procurement portal only. Tender Documents, schedule, specifications are available on the website: www.kppp.karnataka.gov.in Tender form fees & EMD details are available on the kpp portal. EMD and tender processing fees shall be paid using E-Procurement payment modes only. Tender application must be accompanied by earnest money deposit specified for the works and shall have to be valid for 45 days beyond the validity of tender date.
Sd/- Commissioner,
Karnataka Slum Development Board, Bangalore
DIPR/CP/JA/218/2026-27

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER
e-Tender Notice No. : EL-CON-RNC-ELS-26-2, dated 15.04.2026. e-Tender is invited by Assistant Electrical Engineer (Con), S.E.Railway, Ranchi for and on behalf of the President of India for the following work.
Following tender has been uploaded on website www.ireps.gov.in The tender will be closed at 12.00 hrs. on due date. **Brief Description of Works:** Supply, erection, testing & commissioning of 25KV OHE electrification and modification works at Hatia Electric Loco Trip Shed including General Services work in connection with the Construction of new Electric Loco Trip Shed at Hatia in Ranchi Division of South Eastern Railway. **Value of Work:** ₹ 2,22,81,631.10. **Bid Security :** ₹ 4,45,600/-. **Completion period :** 18 Months. Interested tenderers may visit website www.ireps.gov.in [E-Tender → Works (login with phone no.) and search with above mentioned tender no.] for full details/description/specification of the tenders and submit their bids online. In no case manual tenders for these items will be accepted. **N.B. :** Prospective Bidders may regularly visit www.ireps.gov.in to participate in all other tenders. (PR-54)

CENTRAL RAILWAY
SIGNALING WORK
OPEN TENDER NOTICE
Divisional Railway Manager (S&T), 1st Floor, Parcel Office Building, above P.F.No.14 & 15, Central Railway, Mumbai CST 400 001, for and on behalf of the President of India Invites Open tenders from the reputed contractors. **S.No.-1. Name of work:-** Signalling work in connection with Provision of Remote Monitoring and Predictive Maintenance System (RDPMS) at various 10 stations including SE-NE ghat section stations of Mumbai Division of central railway. **TENDER NOTICE NO.CR-BB-SNT-SOUTH-2026-35. Approximate Cost:-** Rs. 7.93/-Crore. **Date of Openings:-** 11/05/2026. **EMD:-** Rs. 1527300/- **Validity:-** 60 days. **Completion Period:-** 12 Months. This tender complies with Public Procurement Policy (Make in India) Order 2017, dated 15/06/2017. Complete details of tenders are available at Central Railway. Official website www.ireps.gov.in in the complete tender documents can be downloaded from the website. The complete details of tenders are also available in the "Notice Board" of the Divisional Railway Manager (S&T)'s Office, Mumbai CST. **56**
Traveling with dangerous and explosive goods is a punishable offense

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
Mechanical Department of East Central Railway invites "Expression of Interest" for Engagement of Professional Housekeeping Agencies for Enhanced and High-Quality On Board Services in Coaching Trains over ECR. The responses must be submitted in sealed envelope with necessary document to the Office of PCME/ECR, Room No.29, Third Floor, Mechanical Department, E. C Railway, Headquarters office, Hajipur, Vaishali, PIN-844101 and a copy via email to ecrcenhm@gmail.com. Applications should reach up to 15:00hrs on or before 28.04.2026. The detail EOI along with Terms & conditions may be downloaded from <http://ecr.indianrailways.gov.in>. **Correspondence Address:** Chief Environment & Housekeeping Manager O/o Pr.CME, East Central Railway Headquarter, Hajipur-844101
PR/0074/HQ/EnHM/N/26-27/48 **CEnHM/ECR/HJP**

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA, HOME DEPARTMENT
(PORTS & TRANSPORT)
MAHARASHTRA MARITIME BOARD
Indian Mercantile Chambers, 2nd Floor, Ramjibhai Kamani Marg, Ballard Estate, Mumbai-400 001. Tel.: 022-69047777 Fax: 022-69041740
Website: <https://mahammb.maharashtra.gov.in>
Email: ceo.mmb@maharashtra.gov.in ceommb@gmail.com
Second E-Tender Notice – (Year 2026-27)
Main Portal: <https://mahatenders.gov.in>
Digitally signed E-Tender for following work is invited by Chief Executive Officer, Maharashtra Maritime Board, Mumbai, from Registered with Government of Maharashtra in appropriate class and having experience in Project Management Consultant, for following work in B1 Tender Form.

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Earnest Money Amount in Rs.	Blank Tender form amount in Rs.
1	Appointment of Project Management Consultancy Services for Construction of Ro-Ro Jetty at Uttan Dongri Tal. Dist. Thane.	1,50,000/-	1,180/-

The details can be viewed online and downloaded directly from the Government of Maharashtra E-Tendering Portal <https://mahatenders.gov.in> on **21.04.2026 at 10:00 to 28.04.2026 at 17:00** hours (IST)
The right to reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason is reserved.
Sd/-
Executive Engineer,
Maharashtra Maritime Board, Mumbai
DGIPR/2026-2027/237

‘Delimitation with old data can upset electoral framework’

NEWS ANALYSIS

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court cautioned in 2025 that delimitation conducted on Census data gathered prior to 2026 risked destabilising the “uniform electoral framework” envisaged by the Constitution and blurring the clear demarcation between constitutional prescription and political discretion.

The court was dealing with a plea for the conduct of delimitation of Assembly seats in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. The petitioner, K. Purushottam Reddy, had argued that by conducting delimitation in the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir in 2022, the Centre was discriminating against the two States. The plea had sought parity.

The court highlighted that even “legitimate expectations” of the electorate could not overawe the constitutional embargo under the provisos to Articles 82 and 170 of the Constitution that “no readjustment of seats or division of States into territorial constituencies can be undertaken until the relevant data from the first census conducted after 2026 is published”. The court said isolated departures from the constitutional embargo for the sake of two States would amount to an impermissible deviation from the equality principle embedded in Article 14 of the Constitution.

Rejecting the plea, the court held that a “contravention of the constitutional timeline provided under Article 170(3) would not only destabilise the uniform electoral framework envisaged by the Constitution but also blur the clear demarcation between constitutional prescription



The court has held that it can intervene if delimitation is found to be arbitrary.

and political discretion”.

The stand of the top court gains significance with the Parliament holding a three-day Special Session from Thursday to debate the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill and Delimitation Bill.

Judicial review limited

The Supreme Court has consistently held that though judicial review of delimitation was limited, the court could intervene if the exercise was capricious and unreasonable.

The court, in the 1975 case of *Indira Nehru Gandhi versus Raj Narain*, said the Constitution empowered Parliament with the task of framing electoral laws for “free and fair elections”, which included “delimitation of constituencies and allotment of seats” to Parliament and the State legislatures.

The Constitution expected the legislature to ensure that these laws upheld representative and equitable democracy. On that trust, it had limited the power of the courts to intervene.

The court’s 2024 decision in the *Kishorchandra Chhanganlal Rathod* case has tilted away from the inviolability of the delimitation exercise. It held that it could certainly intervene if the delimitation was found to be “manifestly arbitrary and irreconcilable to constitutional values”.

TDP sought clarity from govt. on South’s seat share

A.P. CM Chandrababu Naidu spoke to Home Minister Amit Shah and Law Minister Arjun Meghwal over concerns on ambiguity in delimitation Bill; party ‘satisfied’ with Shah’s assurance in Lok Sabha

Sobhana K. Nair
Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

The explicit silence in the draft legislation on delimitation on retaining the current proportion of seats of States prompted the Telugu Desam Party, a key National Democratic Alliance member, to reach out to Home Minister Amit Shah and Law Minister Arjun Meghwal on Wednesday.

The two Ministers had reassured Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu that the strength of southern States in the Lok Sabha will not be diluted, an assurance reiterated by Mr. Shah in the Lok Sabha on Thursday. However, as per sources, the government does not plan to introduce any amendments to either the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026 or the Delimitation Bill, 2026 to clear this ambiguity.

Mr. Shah informed the Lok Sabha that Andhra Pradesh’s strength in the Lok Sabha would increase from 25 seats to 38, its share going up from 4.6%



Home Minister Amit Shah informed the Lok Sabha that Andhra Pradesh’s strength will increase from 25 seats to 38. FILE PHOTO

to 4.65%. He read out the corresponding figure for other southern States too.

On Tuesday afternoon, the government had circulated a legislative package of three Bills – the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, and the Delimitation Bill, 2026. While these Bills accelerate the implementation of reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies, they also advance the timeline for delimitation by basing it on the latest

available Census, which in this case is the 2011 Census.

For the TDP, the removal of the freeze of seats based on population figures of 1971 Census – as the draft Bills state – was deeply worrisome, especially since Mr. Naidu, as part of the NDA under Atal Bihari Vajpayee, had been instrumental in the freezing of Lok Sabha seats till 2026. He felt that this was very much his legacy issue.

The party deputed Bapatla MP Krishna Prasad Tenneti to meet Mr. Megh-

wal on Wednesday. Party functionaries reached out to senior bureaucrats in the Law Ministry.

According to informed sources, Mr. Tenneti conveyed the party’s view that any ambiguity in the legislation could lead to confusion among the southern States. It is learnt that Mr. Naidu spoke to Mr. Shah and Mr. Meghwal over the phone.

Mr. Shah, sources said, assured him that necessary safeguards would be provided and that the strength of the southern States would not be diluted. It was, as per sources, also suggested by the government that if need be, they will introduce amendments for further clarity. However, the government is unlikely to do so.

The TDP, according to the sources, is satisfied by the assurance given by Mr. Shah in the Lok Sabha and is unlikely to press the matter further. The TDP expressed concern that the legislation ignored the long-standing demand to grant voting rights to associate members of the Delimitation Commission.

Support Delimitation Bill if Odisha’s interests are protected: Naveen to MPs

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

A day after Biju Janata Dal (BJD) supremo Naveen Patnaik urged Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Majhi to convene a Special Session of the Assembly to discuss the Delimitation Bill, he appealed to MPs from the State to support the amendment, provided Od-

isha’s share of representation is neither reduced nor compromised.

In a letter to the MPs on Thursday, the veteran leader said, “The proposed linkage between women’s reservation and the delimitation process... has far-reaching implications.”

“States like Odisha, which have made significant strides in population

control and human development are being penalized. A disproportionate increase in Lok Sabha seats in more populous States could skew the allocation of central resources and policy attention,” said the former Chief Minister. “This may adversely impact Odisha’s share in national development priorities, fiscal transfers, and

infrastructure investments,” he said.

Mr. Patnaik urged MPs irrespective of party-affiliations to carefully consider the broader implications of the Bill.

“We should only support the Amendment if Odisha’s share of representations is in no way reduced or compromised,” the BJD leader said.

‘Linking Bills on quota law, delimitation a conspiracy’

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Thursday alleged that linking Bills related to women’s reservation and the proposed delimitation commission was a “conspiracy” to delete voters’ names from electoral rolls and implement the National Register of Citizens (NRC).

Addressing a rally at Mathabhanga in Cooch Behar district, Ms. Banerjee said attempts were being made to “divide India” by linking the two issues.

“Attempts are being made to divide India by linking women’s reservation and delimitation Bills. Connecting these two Bills is a conspiracy to delete voters’ names and implement NRC,” she said.

Ms. Banerjee questioned why the women’s reservation law was not implemented earlier.

She said, 37% of its elected MPs in the Lok Sabha are women.

Referring to Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman’s alleged distribution of “cards” during her visit to West Bengal on Wednesday, Ms. Banerjee challenged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to remove Ms. Sitharaman from the ministerial post for allegedly violating the Model Code of Conduct (MCC).

Cong. MP calls for all-party meeting on women’s quota

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress MP K.C. Venugopal on Thursday asked the government to withdraw the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026 in its current form and call an all-party meeting to evolve a consensus on implementing the women’s reservation.

Participating in a discussion on the Bill in the Lok Sabha, he said the government’s intention was to push through delimitation in the garb of the Women’s Reservation Bill.

‘Sabotaging democracy’

“In the name of women’s reservation, you are trying to sabotage the democracy. You are trying to diminish the status of the States for political ends,” he said.

He said that if the government was really sincere about women’s reservation, it could have implemented it from 2024 general elections itself, as demanded by the Congress.

“Do it now. The entire Opposition is giving you the blank cheque. Give reservation to women as per 2023 Bill against the existing strength of the Parliament.”

The Congress general secretary noted that the Prime Minister, during his



K.C. Venugopal

entire speech on the Bill, did not mention the word “delimitation” even once, though it was the main issue today as the women’s reservation Bill had already been passed in 2023.

Mr. Venugopal claimed that the government’s purpose in holding the Special Session was to project the Opposition as opposing the women’s reservation Bill, which actually is not the case.

The Congress leader said that the government’s intention was clear – to push through delimitation in order to win the 2029 general elections using the Delimitation Commission in the same manner as it had done in Assam and Jammu and Kashmir.

He reminded the government that all previous delimitations had been carried out through consensus and urged it to convene an all-party meeting.

Women MPs welcome Bill, against its ‘weaponisation’

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Women MPs cutting across party lines on Thursday, weighing in on the debate on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill on women’s reservation and those bringing in delimitation, cited, in several instances, the positive role of the founders and leaders of their parties in enabling the participation of women in jobs, education, and politics.

Byreddy Shabari of the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), a constituent of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), invoked the legacy of the party’s founder, N.T. Rama Rao (NTR), to argue that the idea of women-led development was not new. She described this as “the beginning of a vision for women-led development”.

Ms. Shabari pointed to what she described as “pioneering steps” under NTR, including “the first party to announce 30% reservation for women in government jobs when the country was still debating Backward Class quotas”. The amendments to the Constitution brought in by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, she said, were a landmark step in enshrining greater participation of women in parliamentary affairs.

Shambhavi of the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP), also a NDA ally, framed the Bill as



Praniti Shinde and Prabha Mallikarjun, MPs, at a press meet on women’s quota in New Delhi on Thursday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

a historic corrective. “A statesman thinks of future generations; a politician thinks of the next election,” she said, praising party leader Chirag Paswan for fielding “40% women candidates without any legal requirement”. “Because of him, a 25-year-old like me can represent Bihar,” she said.

“Women have long been seen as silent voters; it is time they are seen as law-makers,” she said, accusing the Opposition of lacking “political will” despite past parliamentary majorities.

However, Pratima Mondal of the Trinamool Congress offered a sharp dissent. “We will never oppose a women’s Bill, but we oppose its weaponisation,” she said, demanding 50% reservation for women. Describing the proposals as “electoral engineering”, she warned they would “redraw India’s democratic map”, and accused the government of

acting out of a “fear of electoral defeat”.

Praniti Shinde of the Congress accused Mr. Modi of using saccharine language to couch deception. “If they were sincere, they would have brought this Bill in 2024 [Lok Sabha election] itself. Their real motive is to fraudulently bring in the Delimitation Bill. There is no relationship between the two. They are conveying that women can only benefit from reservation if there are additional seats. Prime Minister Modi is trying to trick the people of the country with sweet words,” Ms. Shinde said.

Adding a note of caution, Joba Majhi of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) said effective implementation would require accurate data.

“Without a proper count of tribals and disadvantaged groups, women from these communities may not benefit,” she said.

Left parties oppose delimitation, back women’s reservation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Left parties argued in the Lok Sabha on Thursday that without specifying the provision under which a 50% increase in number of seats after delimitation had been promised, the Union government was committing an injustice towards States that had performed well in population control.

Communist Party of India-Marxist (CPI-M) MP S. Venkatesan, and Revolutionary Socialist Party (RSP) MP N.K. Premachandran said that if passed in the present form, the Bill would take away the Constitutional rights of southern States.

The Opposition would fight for the rights of Tamil Nadu, Mr. Venkatesan said. Tamil Nadu had been promised it would have 60 MPs, but the government was silent on the Census under which such an increase of Lok Sabha seats would be carried out after the passage of the Bill.

“If it is under the 2011 Census, Tamil Nadu will get 51 MPs. If it is under the 2026 Census, the State will get 47 MPs,” he said, questioning the stand taken by the government.

Under 1971 Census, Tamil Nadu and Bihar had almost the same population of 4.1 crore and 4.2 crore,

MPs argue that the Bill in its present form will take away the rights of southern States

respectively, and were allotted 39 and 40 MPs, respectively. “Now the population in Tamil Nadu is 7.6 crore, and for Bihar it is 12.3 crore – almost double. Now, we must know under which Census you will decide our number of MPs,” Mr. Venkatesan said. Citing the social development indices in Tamil Nadu, he said the Centre was punishing the State for sending children to schools and achieving progress in healthcare.

Mr. Premachandran said the Opposition fully supported women’s reservation, and opposed the Delimitation Bill. “Under the guise of women’s reservation, the government is coming up with a delimitation proposal. They have an ulterior political motive of grabbing power through delimitation,” he said, adding that the proposal was unscientific. “Under what provision will the power to increase seats be given?” he said. “There is no logical explanation for the government’s claim that 50% seats will be increased,” Mr. Premachandran said.

IN BRIEF



Implement women’s quota after caste census: SP chief

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday asked the Centre to operationalise the women’s reservation law only after completing the caste census, accusing the BJP of reducing “*nari*” (women) to a mere “*nara*” (slogan). In the debate in the Lok Sabha on three Bills seeking to amend the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam and implement delimitation, Mr. Yadav alleged that the government was using the proposed changes to delay the Census. He argued that caste census is required to ensure fair representation for women from backward communities. “BJP has made ‘nari’ into a ‘nara’... How many MLAs or MPs of BJP are women?” he said.

Put delimitation on hold, enact women’s quota: Uddhav

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Thursday demanded that the Centre immediately implement the 2023 Act that gives 33% reservation to women in the Lok Sabha and Assemblies and put on hold the process of delimitation of constituencies. In a brief statement in Mumbai, the former Maharashtra Chief Minister said delimitation, or redrawing, of constituencies is not about any one party’s political future, but it is an exercise about nation’s future. Delimitation must be put on hold for now as it is an issue of national importance and needs more discussion, the Opposition politician stated. PTI

J&K, Assam are victims of the delimitation process: PDP

The Peoples’ Democratic Party (PDP) cautioned against moves to push for religion-based delimitation on Thursday, pointing out that “Jammu and Kashmir and Assam are victims of the lopsided delimitation process held recently”. “J&K and Assam are victims of the delimitation process held in 2022... Areas with 20,000 voters in the Jammu division were made constituencies compared to the Kashmir Valley with lakhs of voters which got one,” PDP leader Naeem Akhtar said. Mr. Akhtar said the six seats added to the Jammu division compared to one to the Kashmir division “was aimed at bringing the BJP to power in Muslim-majority J&K”.

Business

INBRIEF



India-Zambia critical minerals talks stall over mining rights

India’s talks with Zambia over critical minerals mining have stalled amid a lack of assurances from Lusaka on mining rights, two sources familiar with the matter told *Reuters*. India last year received an allocation of 9,000 square kms to explore cobalt – a key component in batteries for EVs and mobile phones – as well as copper, widely used in power generation, electronics and construction. India dispatched a team of geologists last year, who have since returned with samples of minerals, including cobalt and copper. The exploration in Zambia was set to run for three years, after which New Delhi had planned to invite private sector companies to participate, subject to securing mining rights.

India could limit sulphur exports as supplies tighten

India is considering a proposal to restrict sulphur exports after industry lobby groups raised concerns about soaring prices and disruption to supplies from the Gulf, three sources aware of the development said. Export restrictions could add to upward pressure on global sulphur prices, as supplies from the Middle East are disrupted by the Iran war and with China also set to restrict sulphuric acid exports from next month. “Sulphur supplies are tightening due to falling imports from the Middle East,” a senior government official told *Reuters*. “Allowing exports could further pressure availability, so discussions are under way on whether exports should be limited.” Sulphur is used to produce fertilisers such as ammonium sulphate and single super phosphate, both widely used in India.

Ashok Leyland says ‘no slack in demand’ in Gulf markets

Commercial vehicle major Ashok Leyland on Thursday said the demand in West Asia is intact; however, production at its UAE-based unit faced some impact due to supply-chain disruptions. About the possible impact of ongoing geopolitical tensions in West Asia on the company’s FY27 performance, Ashok Leyland President – LCV, IO, Defence & Power Solutions, Amandeep Singh, said, “It’s too early” to assess, though the underlying economic momentum in India remains strong. He added that there can be some disruption due to ‘shortage and logistics’ issues from the impact of West Asia disruption, but said the situation is expected to “bounce back” quickly. Ashok Leyland has a good presence in West Asia, anchored by its manufacturing facility in Ras Al Khaimah (RAK), UAE. PTI



Growth boost: Renault’s Francois Provost, right and India CEO Stephane Deblaise at the unveiling of India expansion plan. PTI

Renault to slot India among top 3 markets

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

French automaker Renault plans to position India among top three global markets for Renault brand by 2030. Francois Provost, CEO of Renault Group, who was here in Chennai, unveiled the futuREady plan for India and said new vehicles will be unveiled, bringing its portfolio to seven models in India by 2030. “We have already launched the new Duster, and we are already seeing strong interest and enthusiasm from customers. “India represents more than 1/3 (34%) of the TIV growth in the markets where Renault Group operates. It is one of the fastest

growing automotive markets,” he added. “We want to integrate India more deeply into Renault Group’s global value chain, especially via vehicle and component exports. Our goal is to reach €2 billion annually in exports by 2030. “With futuREady, we are competing in a market of around 50 million vehicles per year, which is more than half of the global market (55%). Our goal is to begin production in India in the second half of next year,” he added. “We will also deploy new technologies in India, with two key platforms: Renault Group Entry Platform and Renault Group Modular Platform.”

Auto sector reaches ‘broad’ consensus on CAFE-III norms

Latest proposal applies flatter compliance curve across five years rather than steep annual tightening, removes relaxations for lighter vehicles

Jagriti Chandra
Lalatendu Mishra
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

A “broad” consensus emerged on the long-contested, upcoming carbon emission norms for cars for 2027 at a high-level inter-ministerial meeting on Thursday, with small car makers making only “minor suggestions”, industry sources said.

The draft proposal of Carbon Average Fuel Efficiency-3 floated by the Bureau of Energy Efficiency in September 2025, which has gone through multiple iterations, had reached a deadlock as the industry remained split between small and large car manufacturers over relaxations to the former.

The latest proposal circulated last week applies a flatter compliance curve across five years rather than steep annual tightening, and removes relaxations offered to lighter vehicles.

Auto industry sources said there was a “broad agreement” over the latest version of CAFE-3 norms at a discussion held with the industry representatives and top officials of the Ministry of Power, Ministry of Heavy Industries and Ministry of Road Transport and Highways.

Some had sought that the government make no further changes to it and notify the latest draft.



Shifting gears: The latest proposal also comprises a super credit scheme in which battery EVs get maximum super credits. REUTERS

“While it is a stretch to meet some of the provisions, we have agreed to comply for the larger national interest,” a top industry source at a Mumbai-based auto firm seeking anonymity said adding they appreciated the Centre’s efforts to incorporate industry views. Another industry representative also seeking not to be named said small car makers remained dissatisfied and had offered suggestions, without elaborating. Some had proposed minor changes to the Centre’s super credit scheme.

Last week’s draft proposes a flatter slope – .00158 instead of .002 in the first year and .00131 in the fifth year.

The slope, expressed in grams of CO₂ per kilometre per unit of vehicle mass, determines how emission targets vary with a vehicle’s weight. It also removes weight-based relaxations for smaller cars. But

a flatter curve is understood to have the effect of tightening targets for heavier vehicles while reducing the targets for those below the industry average weight of 1,229 kg.

The latest version also comprises a super credit scheme within which battery electric vehicles and range extended electric vehicles have the maximum super credits at 3. Within this scheme, the sale of each EV is counted as a sale of multiple EVs helping raise the average of the fleet and in reaching the emission targets.

The September draft had split the industry, with Maruti on one side and Mahindra and Tata on the other. Larger carmakers argued that the weight-based carve-out favoured Maruti’s small-car-heavy portfolio while shifting the compliance burden onto companies that had invested heavily in EVs and cleaner technologies.

EU planning to include 180 more products under CBAM

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The European Union (EU) is planning to include 180 more products under the scope of its Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism

(CBAM) from January 2028, a move that could increase carbon tax costs on Indian-manufactured exports to Europe.

The European Parliament’s Committee on the Environment, Climate and

Food Safety has recommended the expansion of the scope of CBAM.

The European Commission has come forward with this proposal, following the transitional phase of the CBAM (2023-2025).

Govt. on ‘wait and watch’ mode as U.S. declines to extend waivers on Russia, Iran crude purchases

Saptaparno Ghosh
Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

A day after the U.S. declined to extend the duration of waivers for procurement of Russian and Iranian crude, officials with knowledge of the development informed that the Centre was in a “wait and watch” mode given the frequent changes in the United States’ policies.

The U.S. Department of Treasury, on March 12 and March 20, had extended waivers on purchase of oil from the two countries amid the impact on oil supplies globally because of the escalating tensions in West Asia, especially at the crucial energy route Strait of Hormuz.

The waiver on purchase of Russian oil, which also included from sanctioned entities, expired on April



Scott Bessent

11, while the waiver on Iranian oil stranded at sea is set to expire on April 19.

On Wednesday, Scott Bessent, Secretary of the U.S. Treasury, categorically denied renewing the waiver on both Russian and Iranian crude.

The official told *The Hindu* that procuring energy from sanctioned entities of the two countries had become virtually impossible for private refiners in India. He added that Indian oil companies were seeking out companies that had

not been sanctioned although they may not fill the shortfall in energy demand.

‘Actively diversifying’
As a result, the official said the government was actively diversifying energy purchases from more countries, including Africa, South America, and increasingly from the U.S. itself.

In fact, on Wednesday, Sergio Gor, Washington’s Ambassador to India met Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri seeking to “advance the U.S.-India energy partnership”.

In a social media post, the Ambassador to India mentioned, “Expanding access to reliable American energy will further deepen our economic ties and support long-term energy security and diversity for both nations.”

Wipro Q4 net profit declines almost 2%

Mini Tejaswi
BENGALURU

Wipro on Thursday posted Q4 net profit of ₹3,502 crore, an almost 2% decline from ₹3,570 crore in the year-earlier period.

On a sequential basis, the company reported a 12% jump in net profit to ₹3,502 crore, compared with ₹3,119 crore in the third quarter of FY26.

The March-ended quarter saw Wipro’s revenue rising 8% to ₹24,236 crore compared with ₹22,504 crore in the corresponding year-ago period. IT services segment revenue during the quarter was at \$2,651.0 million, an increase of 0.6% QoQ and 2.1% YoY.

Biswajit Maity, Senior Principal Analyst at Gartner, told *The Hindu* that Wipro’s Q4 FY26 results reflected stable performance despite market volatility. Gross revenue rose 2.9% quarter-on-quarter and

The Bengaluru based IT firm announced its biggest-ever ₹15,000 crore share buyback

7.7% year-on-year, while IT services revenue posted a slight gain, indicating ongoing client caution in spending.

Srini Pallia, CEO and Managing Director, said advancements in AI were reshaping client priorities and creating new opportunities for the company to partner more deeply to deliver value-driven outcomes.

In its largest-ever buyback, Wipro’s Board of Directors, in the recently concluded board meeting, announced a share buyback of ₹15,000 crore at a price of ₹250, subject to shareholder approval, informed Chief Financial Officer Aparna Iyer.

Bank earnings may see cuts on prolonged West Asia crisis

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Bank earnings are expected to face headwinds on continued stress in West Asia even as their balance sheets are healthy, according to analyst reports.

The analysts said that bank loans were expected to grow at a pace of 11-13% in fiscal 2027, with BNP Paribas cutting its estimates by 3 percentage points to 11%. Researchers, however, forecast that normalcy would return in a month and this would mean there would be no major rate increases. “These estimates currently do not build in a deep bear scenario where oil and gas supplies are majorly disrupted for an extended period with concurrent economic dislocation from the supply shock,” BNP Paribas said in its note.

SC refuses to stay HC order on fraud trial against Anil Ambani

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court found no ground to interfere with Bombay High Court’s February 23 order opening the door for fraud classification proceedings to continue against Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG) founder Anil Ambani.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant did not intervene in the Division Bench decision to set aside a single judge order of December last year, which stalled the proceedings.

The SC, however, said observations made by the Division Bench would not affect the merit of the civil suit filed by Mr. Ambani challenging the qualifications of the forensic auditor, an entity called BDO India LLP and its Forensic Audit Report (FAR) of October 2020.

The businessman argued that the signatory to the FAR was not a qualified Chartered Accountant.

The SC gave Mr. Ambani liberty to pursue the civil suit and any other remedy available to him.

SC recorded statement that Ambani wished to settle but did not express an opinion

Senior advocates Kapil Sibal and Shyam Divan urged to record the statement of their client Ambani who was willing to ‘sit with the banks and settle’.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the consortium of creditors of public sector banks, said a recording of such a statement by the court would have “repercussions”, especially when separate criminal proceedings were under way in the case.

“They (banks) have settled so many accounts with people sitting abroad... You should not be a stumbling block to settlement,” Mr. Sibal submitted.

Mr. Mehta said such a statement may tend to influence other courts and fora. The SC finally recorded Mr. Sibal’s statement that his client wanted to settle but said it did not want to express any opinion on it.



GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
DEPARTMENT OF SPACE
CONSTRUCTION AND MAINTENANCE GROUP(CMG)
ISRO Headquarters, Antariksh Bhavan,
New BEL Road, Bengaluru-560 094. Ph: 080 - 2217 2041/2476/5641/5660
Fax.No.: 080-2351 3126, e-mail: ts.cmg@isro.gov.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

On behalf of the President of India, online **EPC tenders** are invited through e-tendering for the following work:

Title of Work	Planning, Design and Construction of Security and Front office at ISRO HQ, Antariksh Bhavan, Bengaluru (Civil, PH, Electrical, AC, Video wall and other allied Security Systems) through EPC Mode-1.	
e-Tender Notice No.	CMG/ISRO-HQ/C/C/01/P/AB/2026-27 dated 15.04.2026	
Estimated Cost put to tender	a) Civil & PH works b) Electrical works c) AC works d) Video wall system	Rs. 267.55 Lakhs Rs. 475.00 Lakhs
	e) Audio visual system, Security Gadgets, Biometric Access Control system, Networking systems, CCTV system and allied works.	Rs. 209.95 Lakhs
	Total	Rs. 952.50 Lakhs
Period of Completion	Six (06) Months	
Period during which the tender document can be downloaded	From 18:10 hrs on 15.04.2026 To: 23:59 hrs on 28.04.2026	
Last date & time for receipt of tenders	up to 15:30 hrs on 06.05.2026	
Due date & time of opening of tenders (Techno-Commercial Bid)	16:00 hrs on 06.05.2026	
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	Rs. 19.05 Lakhs	
For eligibility criteria and other details, Interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi/English) Notice Inviting Tender (NIT) on website https://isro.gov.in/tenders.html and tender free view at https://tenderwizard.com/ISRO . Detailed Notice Inviting Tender (NIT) and tender documents may be downloaded from e-tendering website https://tenderwizard.com/ISRO Sd/- Head, CMD, ISRO HQ		



HON'BLE SUPREME COURT MONITORED PROJECTS
Executed Through
NBCC (INDIA) LIMITED
(A Navratna PSU of Govt. of India)
Through E-Auction
Sale of Tech Park project at Knowledge Park-V, Greater Noida (W), UP of erstwhile Amrapali Group through NBCC.
Interested parties may register themselves on RAILTEL (The agency engaged by NBCC (INDIA) LTD for holding e-auction) or on website <https://nbccauction.envida.com>.
Last date for submission of EMD is 23.04.2026.
E-Auction will be held on 24.04.2026.
For Details, Please call: 9772907414



GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA
PUBLIC HEALTH AND MUNICIPAL ENGINEERING DEPARTMENT
NIT No. 1504/DB/D3/Real Time Monitoring/2025-26 Dt: 15.04.2026
01 Work costing Rs. 1000.00 Lakhs: Providing Real Time Monitoring System (Part of SCADA) from Reservoirs to ELSRs/GLSRs in ULBs. **Closing on Dt: 04.05.2026 @ 4:30 PM;** For details visit <https://tender.telangana.gov.in>. Contact:- 9154299724.
Sd/- Superintending Engineer (PH) West Circle, Hyderabad
DIPR R.O.No.771-PP/CL/ADVT/2026-27 Dt. 16.04.2026



कार्यालय जिला परिषद भीलवाड़ा
क्रमांक :- लेखा/निविदा/प्रिन्टिंग/2026/30006 दिनांक :- 09/04/2026
E-Bid Invitation Notice
Bids for Printing, Computer & Com. Stationary and Stationary Items are invited from interested bidders up to 01.05.2026 till 1:00 PM. Other particulars of the bids may be visited on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>) of the State.
NIB NO - ZBL2627A0012
UBN - ZBL2627GLRC00034 E-Proc Id - 2026_PRD_551167_1
UBN - ZBL2627WSRC00035 E-Proc Id - 2026_PRD_551058_1
UBN - ZBL2627GLRC00036 E-Proc Id - 2026_PRD_551080_1
साथ ही इस कार्यालय द्वारा <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर जारी E-Proc Id - 2026_PRD_551013_1 से जारी निविदा को निरस्त किया जाता है।
मुख्य कार्यकारी अधिकारी
राज.संवाद/सी/26/954 जिला परिषद भीलवाड़ा



READ
FRONTLINE
LEADING THE DEBATE SINCE 1984
EVERY FORTNIGHT.
TO SUBSCRIBE, VISIT
www.thehindugroup.in/subscribe

Israeli forces killed a 17-year-old Palestinian in the occupied West Bank on Thursday, according to Palestinian officials, as the Israeli military said its troops had “neutralised a terrorist”. According to the Palestinian news agency *Wafa*, the Israeli army was carrying out “a wide-scale search operation targeting several homes”. AFP

Syria said on Thursday that it had taken control of Qasrak air base in Hasakeh province in the northeast after forces from the U.S.-led international coalition against the Islamic State group withdrew. Qasrak was considered a key U.S. base in northeast Syria and served as a logistics hub for convoys heading towards Iraq. AFP

The United States will blockade Iranian ports for “as long as it takes,” U.S. Secretary of War Pete Hegseth said on Thursday, threatening renewed strikes if Tehran does not make a deal. “If Iran chooses poorly, they will have a blockade and bombs dropping on infrastructure, power and energy,” Mr. Hegseth said. [AFP](#)

Rescuers in Germany began an elaborate operation on Thursday to save a sick humpback whale that has been repeatedly stranded off the Baltic Sea coast. Experts have come up with a sophisticated plan to use air cushions to lift the animal onto a tarp, which will be secured to two pontoons and attached to a tugboat. AP

MILESTONE ALERT

Arshdeep becomes first PBKS bowler to bag 100 wickets in IPL



EMMANUAL YOGINI

Arshdeep Singh became the first Punjab Kings bowler to pick up 100 wickets in the IPL. The 27-year-old pacer achieved the feat when he had Ryan Rickelton caught in the match against Mumbai Indians on Thursday. Veteran leg-spinner Piyush Chawla's 84 wickets is the next best for PBKS.

RARE FEAT

De Kock is the first wicketkeeper to score three IPL centuries



EMMANUAL YOGINI

Mumbai Indians opener Quinton de Kock became the first wicketkeeper to score three IPL centuries, achieving the milestone against Punjab Kings on Thursday. De Kock made an unbeaten 112 off 60 balls. The 33-year-old is also the third player after K.L. Rahul and Sanju Samson to notch up tons for three IPL franchises.

PERSONNEL CHANGE

Bhagat replaces injured Ankolekar in MI squad; SRH's Payne ruled out



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Mumbai Indians named young Punjab all-rounder Krish Bhagat (in pic) as a replacement for the injured Atharva Ankolekar for the remainder of IPL 2026. Sunrisers Hyderabad was dealt another injury setback with England left-arm seamer David Payne being ruled out of the league due to an ankle injury.

RECOVERY MODE

I am not 100%, but I am happy with my intensity, says Kohli



K. MURALI KUMAR

Royal Challengers Bengaluru batter Virat Kohli said he "felt much better" but was still not 100%. "The knee was sore in the last game, and I was under the weather. But I am happy with my intensity. The pitch was slower than usual; there was not enough grass on it," said Kohli after RCB's win over Lucknow Super Giants.

Prabhsimran and Shreyas sizzle as rampant PBKS crushes MI to go top

The duo's century stand powers the visitor to victory with 21 balls to spare; Arshdeep's early strikes jolt home side; de Kock's ton in vain

IPL-19

Shayan Acharya
MUMBAI

Prabhsimran Singh brought up his second half-century of the season as Punjab Kings aced another tall chase, this time against Mumbai Indians, to maintain its unbeaten run in the IPL.

As a packed Wankhede Stadium cheered for the home team on Thursday, the in-form Prabhsimran continued his dream run with an unbeaten 80 off 39 balls, forging a 139-run partnership with captain Shreyas Iyer (66, 35b, 5x4, 4x6) for the third wicket to ensure that Punjab chased down Mumbai Indians' 195 for six and sealed a seven-wicket win.

Quinton de Kock, stepping in for the injured Rohit Sharma, smashed an unbeaten 112 off 60 balls while Naman Dhir made the most of a reprieve to score a fifty. They put on 122 runs off 68 balls for the third wicket, helping Mumbai recover from 12 for two. Punjab began briskly and raced to 21 in the opening over before A.M. Ghazanfar struck twice to remove Priyansh Arya and Cooper Connolly. However, Prabhsimran



Awesome twosome: Prabhsimran and Shreyas toyed with the MI bowling. EMMANUAL YOGINI

quickly took charge and ensured there were no further hiccups. Keeping the required rate under control, he played freely and punished anything loose, while rotating strike effectively.

At the other end, Shreyas complemented him perfectly, playing the sheet-anchor role, before eventually clearing the ropes. The duo mixed caution with aggression, steadily closing in on the target

with a composed approach.

As the partnership blossomed, Mumbai's bowlers struggled to make an impact, as none could find a breakthrough. It turned into another wicketless outing for Jasprit Bumrah, adding to Mumbai's concerns.

Earlier, Arshdeep Singh gave Punjab the perfect start by removing Ryan Rickelton and Suryakumar Yadav off successive

deliveries.

Though Mumbai recovered through de Kock and Naman's knocks, the total proved insufficient on a good batting surface, as Punjab's clinical chase underlined its dominance and consistency.

With the chase executed with authority and calm, Punjab again showcased its depth and balance, leaving MI with plenty to ponder as its campaign continued to stutter.

SCOREBOARD

MUMBAI INDIANS
Ryan Rickelton c Shashank b Arshdeep 2 (8b), Quinton de Kock (not out) 112 (60b, 8x4, 7x6), Suryakumar Yadav c Chahal b Arshdeep 0 (1b), Naman Dhir c Bartlett b Shashank 50 (31b, 3x4, 3x6), Hardik Pandya c Bartlett b Jansen 14 (12b, 1x6), Sherfane Rutherford b Arshdeep 1 (5b), Tilak Varma (run out) 8 (3b, 2x4), Mayank Rawat (not out) 0 (0b); Extras (lb-4, w-4) 8; Total (for six wkts. in 20 overs) 195.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-27 (Priyansh, 2.2), 2-45 (Connolly, 4.3), 3-184 (Shreyas, 15.3).

MUMBAI INDIANS BOWLING
Chahar 2.3-0-45-0, Bumrah 4-0-41-0, Ghazanfar 4-0-31-2, Hardik 3-0-39-0, Shardul 3-0-42-1. **Toss:** Kings.

PoM: Arshdeep. Punjab Kings won by seven wickets with 21 balls remaining.

KINGS BOWLING	
Arshdeep 4-0-22-3, Jansen 4-0-30-1, Bartlett 4-0-39-0, Vyshak 3-0-36-0, Chahal 3-0-45-0, Shashank 2-0-19-1.	
PUNJAB KINGS	
Priyansh Arya c Chahar b Ghazanfar 15 (9b, 2x4, 1x6), Prabhsimran Singh (not out) 80	

Next assignment

PBKS: April 19 vs. LSG New Chandigarh, 7.30 p.m.
MI: April 20 vs. GT Ahmedabad, 7.30 p.m.

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Punjab Kings	5	4	0	1	9	1.067
Royal Challengers	5	4	1	0	8	1.503
Rajasthan Royals	5	4	1	0	8	0.889
Sunrisers Hyderabad	5	2	3	0	4	0.576
Delhi Capitals	4	2	2	0	4	0.322
Gujarat Titans	4	2	2	0	4	-0.029
Lucknow Super Giants	5	2	3	0	4	-0.804
Chennai Super Kings	5	2	3	0	4	-0.846
Mumbai Indians	5	1	4	0	2	-1.076
Kolkata Knight Riders	5	0	4	1	1	-1.383

KKR stands between GT and a hat-trick of wins

Amol Karhadkar
AHMEDABAD

Gujarat Titans returns to the familiar comforts of the Narendra Modi Stadium with momentum on its side as it gears up to face Kolkata Knight Riders in Friday's Indian Premier League clash.

Back-to-back away wins have lent a certain assurance to Shubman Gill's men, and more importantly, their core has begun to click. Gill's silken touch at the top has been complemented by Jos Buttler rediscovering his fluency, the duo laying the foundation for totals of substance. It has, in many ways, echoed Titans' tried-and-tested template – a dominant top order setting the tone.

With the batters doing the heavy lifting, Rashid Khan's return to the wickets column has further rounded off a unit that suddenly looks well-balanced. The Afghanistan leg-spinner's knack of striking in the middle-overs adds bite to an attack that thrives on control as much as it does on breakthroughs.

With the top-three firing



Varun. VIJAY SONEJI

and Rashid regaining rhythm, Titans will fancy its chances of completing a hat-trick of wins.

If Titans arrives with wind in its sails, Kolkata Knight Riders finds itself searching for direction. The only winless team so far in IPL 2026, Ajinkya Rahane's side has been hamstrung by injuries and an unsettled combination. The lack of continuity has reflected in its performance,

Today's match



Ahmedabad, 7.30 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 4

GT 3 | KKR 1

PREVIOUS MEETING

GT won by 39 runs, 2025

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIHOTSTAR

es, with neither the batting nor the bowling unit managing to stamp authority.

Much of the spotlight will be on Cameron Green to justify his hefty price tag with a match-defining contribution. With Matheesha Pathirana unavailable despite being cleared by Sri Lanka Cricket, KKR's bowling responsibilities will rest heavily on Kartik Tyagi, who has shown promise, and the seasoned spin duo of Varun Chakravarthy and Sunil Narine.

For KKR, rediscovering its spin chokehold could be the key. But against a Gujarat side finding its groove, the task at hand appears anything but straightforward.

Hazlewood is 'looking sharper', feels Jitesh

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

Ahead of the IPL 2026 season, the single biggest concern for Royal Challengers Bengaluru was its bowling.

Josh Hazlewood, the 22-wicket star of the title-winning run in 2025, hadn't played in over four months because of hamstring and Achilles injuries. Yash Dayal, who totalled 28 wickets across two seasons, was unavailable for off-field reasons.

Five games into the ongoing campaign, it appears that RCB has very few holes in its bowling attack.

But for Rajasthan Royals' Vaibhav Suryavanshi-inspired onslaught, the defending champion was bowled out Chennai Super Kings, taken nine of Sunrisers Hyderabad's wickets and kept a fearsome Mumbai Indians line-up under control. On Wednesday came its most authoritative effort yet, as it dismissed Lucknow Super Giants for 146. Hazlewood, in a Player-of-the-Match performance, bowled four superb overs for just 20 runs, took the prized scalp of Nicholas Pooran and left



Hazlewood. K. MURALI KUMAR

Rishabh Pant with a damaged left elbow.

"Hazlewood is looking sharper [than last year]," said RCB vice-captain Jitesh Sharma. "He is well rested, has become quicker and fitter, and is confident about his body now."

The ideal foil for Hazlewood was fellow pacer Rasikh Salam, who impressed for a second straight match (4/24). "He had the skills, but now he has learnt how to use them," Jitesh said about Rasikh, who is also his teammate at Baroda. "In domestic cricket, he worked a lot on his yorkers and slower ones. And with practice, it becomes part of your muscle memory".

Ngidi credits Bravo for the development of slower delivery

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

In Lungi Ngidi's recent endeavours in the T20 format, the slower ball has been akin to a silver bullet.

The South African's ability to execute that variation – he has an off-cutter and a leg-cutter in his locker – has been such that it has turned into his signature weapon. It garnered attention during the T20 World Cup, where the pacer finished as Proteas' leading wicket-taker with 12 scalps in seven matches.

The 30-year-old's varied repertoire has continued to be effective for Delhi Capitals in IPL 2026.

Ngidi credits Dwayne Bravo for the development of his dipping slower ball, having learnt it from the West Indian during their stint with Chennai Super Kings in IPL 2018.

"I've been bowling the slower ball for years now. It's just that I give it a bit more flight and a bit more revs. It did take lots of practice. It took me almost a year to get the confi-



Ngidi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

dence to deliver this ball. It has become one of my weapons. There are times when I will get it wrong. But when I get it right, it creates chances," he said over a Zoom call on Thursday.

With the margin for error being minuscule for a bowler, Ngidi went on to elaborate on the ingredients needed to stay relevant in the shortest format.

"It does take a lot mentally. It (the slower one) is a brave ball to bowl because when I get it wrong, it can be a low full toss or a slot ball and can travel for boundaries," he stated. "It takes a lot of confidence. I've got to find ways to succeed while doing that dirty job. It's not getting any easier for us as bowlers".

CSK's Khaleel ruled out due to quadricep injury

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Just when it looked like Chennai Super Kings turned the page with two wins on the bounce, the five-time IPL champion suffered a huge blow as Khaleel Ahmed was ruled out of the remainder of the 19th edition due to a right quadricep injury.

The left-arm pacer limped off before the final delivery of his spell in the victory over Kolkata Knight Riders here on Tuesday. Khaleel's absence would mean a rejig of the combination when it seemed that the team had found the right line-up. Spencer Johnson, Ellis' replacement, is awaiting the NOC from Cricket Australia and could join the squad on Saturday or Sunday.

Meanwhile, M.S. Dhoni travelled to Hyderabad for the contest against Sunrisers Hyderabad on Saturday, but his chances of playing appear remote. Dhoni did not travel for the away fixtures against Rajasthan Royals and Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

Vaishali has worked hard, is much more confident now: coach Ramesh

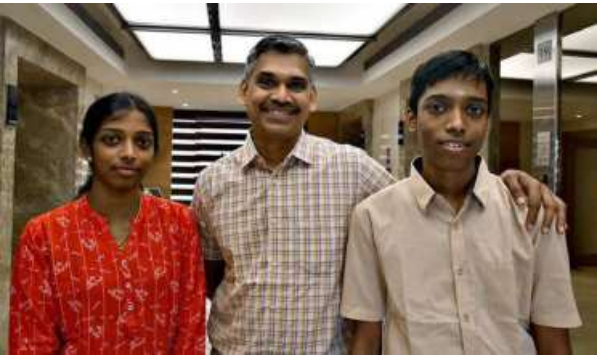
'Qualifying for the World Championship match is an amazing thing and I hope she'll be able to win the title'

CHESS

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

Making history probably comes easy for the R. Vaishali and her brother Praggnanandhaa. The siblings have achieved a few firsts as a duo and individually – the first to become Grandmasters and qualifying for the Candidates tournament.

The 24-year-old Vaishali, long in the shadow of her prodigiously talented brother, chose to make some history of her own after winning the women's Candidates tournament on Wednesday, becoming the



Coach speak: Ramesh feels Pragg's performances don't have any negative impact on Vaishali. FILE PHOTO: SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

first Indian to do so.

She had endured a lean run in 2025 before finding form to claim the Grand Swiss title and book a spot in the Candidates.

Following an epochal triumph in Cyprus, she will take on reigning champion

Ju Wenjun of China for the Women's World Chess Championship title later this year.

Vaishali's long-time coach R.B. Ramesh is over the moon and told *The Hindu*, "qualifying for the World Championship

match is an amazing thing and I hope she'll be able to win the title."

Speaking about the Chennai GM's loss of confidence last year, "yeah, she had some confidence issues earlier, especially after the Chennai GM tournament (last year), but she has been working hard on her game and is feeling much more confident now."

The manner in which Vaishali played during the triumph in the Cypriot city of Paphos should stand her in good stead going forward.

Under the radar

Often flying under the radar given her sibling's achievements, Ramesh

said, "Pragg and Vaishali have made peace with each other being very strong on their own terms. I don't think Pragg's performances have any negative impact on Vaishali anymore."

He said Vaishali is very strong in attack and calculation skills and added, "wish she can improve her time management a bit."

Ramesh believes his ward has benefited a lot from the support she gets from her family and feels she has a good chance at the World title.

More history beckons when Vaishali faces the Chinese with the prospect of becoming the first-ever Indian woman to win the World title.

WADA admits to doping concerns in India, indicates close monitoring of process

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

The World Anti Doping Agency on Thursday declared that doping was a big problem in India and that it would be working closely and monitoring the country's anti-doping process and systems in the coming months.

WADA president Witold Banka and Director of Intelligence and Investigations Günter Younger, addressing select media here, admitted as much after the final conference of the expansion phase of its Global Anti-Doping Intelligence and Investigations Network (GAIIN) in Asia and Oceania.

The one-day meeting brought together represen-

tatives of law enforcement agencies and National Anti-Doping Organisations from 23 countries in Europe and 45 countries across the Asia/Oceania region besides INTERPOL and EUROPOL.

"Operation Upstream is a global operation across continents but there is no doubt that the biggest producer of illegal and performance-enhancing drugs, illegal steroids is in India. Of course, there's no doubt that we have a problem with doping in India. This is an ongoing, confidential operation but there are no doubts that there is a big problem here," Banka was categorical.

While appreciating the support from various Indian agencies, Banka ne-

vertheless made it clear that compliance with WADA rules and cleaning up the house was non-negotiable to India's hopes of hosting major sporting events.

"There is understanding of the problem here, no one is blind on the problem. I was very honest and very clear that we, as WADA, expect stronger engagement and commitment.

"Our expectation is to see how NADA applies the rules, how strong is the system, how the investigation looks like, to assess the educational actions and programmes. India is very ambitious when it comes to organising sporting events, it will not be possible without strong anti-doping policy," he added.

SA series a chance to prepare for T20 WC: skipper Harmanpreet

CRICKET

Press Trust of India
DURBAN

Emphasising the need to give all players adequate opportunities ahead of the T20 World Cup, India captain Harmanpreet Kaur on Thursday said her side is confident and keen to make the most of the five-match T20I series against South Africa, starting here on Friday.

"We want to take this opportunity very seriously

and play our best cricket here. It's a great chance for us to come together and prepare well before the World Cup," Harmanpreet said at the pre-series press conference.

"These matches are important to ensure all players get equal opportunities so that we are fully ready as a unit going into the World Cup. At the same time, we are here to win," she noted.

"After the ODI World Cup, the team is quite confident. Wherever we are going, we are going with

full confidence. The team is in good shape."

On team combinations, she indicated that selections have been guided by South African conditions, particularly the need for multiple pace options, while maintaining faith in the spin attack led by experienced players like Deepti Sharma. She also confirmed that the team management has backed continuity in the wicket-keeping department, while keeping options open based on fitness and domestic performances.

Saravanan, with 14 wickets, scripts Rovers' humongous win

FIRST DIVISION

Sports Bureau

For the second day in succession, left-arm spinner P. Saravanan spun a web around Vijay CC's batters and scalped another seven-wicket haul to bowl Jolly Rovers to a thumping innings and 231-run win on day two of the final TNCA first division league encounter here on Thursday.

Saravanan, who claimed seven for 39 in the first innings, finished with a match haul of 14 for 65.

Resuming the day on 154 for one, Rovers' skip-



Star performers: Saravanan (Rovers, 7/26), Adittya (Young Stars, 164), Chandrasekar (Sea Hawks, 6/45 incl. hat-trick), Radhakrishnan (Trotters, 109 batting) and Indrajith (Rovers, 152 n.o.).

per B. Indrajith slammed an unbeaten 152 to help his team finish on 424 for nine declared at tea with a lead of 299.

In its second essay, Vijay was bundled out for 68 in just 20.2 overs.

At Tagore College, D.T. Chandrasekar's six for 45,

which included a hat-trick, helped Sea Hawks post a seven-wicket win over SKM CC.

The scores:

At SSN: Singam Puli 328 in 106.4 overs (K. Aashiq 40, U. Mukilesh 67, M. Affan Khader 103, R. Sibi 41, R. Sanjay Yadav 4/105) vs. Nelson 205/7 in 70 overs (S. Rithik

Easwaran 51, Robin Bist 53).

At IITM-Chemplast: Vijay 125 & 68 in 20.2 overs (P. Saravanan 7/26) lost to Jolly Rovers 424/9 decl. in 105.2 overs (R. Vimal Khumar 86, B. Sachin 63, B. Indrajith 152 n.o., R.S. Ambrish 52). **Points:** Rovers 6 (43), Vijay 0 (29).

At SRMC: Young Stars 440 in 170.1 overs (M. Mithul Raj 112,

Adittya Varadharajan 164, J. Ajay Chetan 43, B. Aaditya 4/145) vs. MRC 'A' 17/0 in 7 overs.

At Tagore: SKM CC 77 & 104 in 27 overs (D.T. Chandrasekar 6/45) lost to Sea Hawks 129 & 56/3 in 9.4 overs. **Points:** Sea Hawks 6 (41); SKM 0 (27).

At Guru Nanak: Grand Slam 319 in 114.1 overs (L. Suryapprakash 82, Akshay Sarangdnar 46, Arpit Vasavada 46, R.K. Jayant 42, Aryan Sanjay Thakre 50) vs. Jupiter 160/3 in 52 overs (P. Khush Bardia 77 batting).

At MRF-Pachaiyappa's: Alwarpet 340 in 117.5 overs (L.R. Nawin 41, A. Badrinath 93, P. Vidyuth 49 n.o., R. Ram Arvindh 69) vs. Globe Trotters 216/2 in 56 overs (S. Radhakrishnan 109 batting, D. Santhosh Kumar 52).

BUSINESS CONNECT

A Business Initiative

Lalithaa Jewellers Akshaya Tritiya



Lalithaa Jewellery celebrates Akshaya Tritiya with an offering that emphasises tradition, trust, and unmatched value. This year, it presents prices lower than its already competitive rates, guaranteeing customers more for every rupee spent. "At Lalithaa, our focus has always been simple, to give customers the maximum value for their money," says Kiran Kumar, Chairman. Customers can enjoy 1 percent less on the prevailing gold rate for gold jewellery, and Rs. 4000 off per carat on diamond jewellery. The offer also includes 0 percent value addition on gold coins and no making charges on 90 percent of silverware. "Our customers are very value-conscious," shares a senior store associate, ensuring transparent pricing. Lalithaa's Akshaya Tritiya campaign combines genuine pricing with emotional value, inviting customers to embark on their journey of prosperity.

Holiday Land at Phoenix Marketcity



Phoenix Market city Chennai presents Holiday Land, a Madagascar-themed celebration that transforms the mall into a vibrant carnival of circus, shopping, and family entertainment. Visitors are transported into a lively Madagascar-inspired universe featuring Afro-jungle dance performances, energetic circus acts, mascot walkabouts, and engaging activity zones designed for families and children. The launch included a countdown and lighting ceremony, unveiling the vibrant installation and kicking off an evening of high-energy performances. Digital creator VJ Sidhu made a special appearance. Throughout the weekend, the Sing Along Chennai Musical Band and ongoing circus acts kept the atmosphere lively.

BoB Launch 'bob World Lite'



Bank of Baroda (BoB) and Reliance Jio announced a partnership launching bob World Lite, designed specifically for feature phone users, on the JioPhone Prima 4G device. It features a lightweight, low-bandwidth architecture with keypad navigation and secure access. The Bob World Lite mobile banking app currently offers UPI-enabled Scan & Pay and Send Money; Bill payments & Recharges and manage profile, with more features to be introduced. Dr Debadatta Chand, MD & CEO, BoB, said, "Driving digital inclusion remains a core priority for us at Bank of Baroda." Dr. Sunil Dutt, President, Reliance Jio Infocomm Limited, said, "At Jio, we have always focused on expanding the reach of digital services to every Indian, at scale and with affordability at the core."

Deputy Governor of RBI at SASTRA



"The emerging role of AI in the financial ecosystem should reduce uncertainties and expand opportunities for all stakeholders to advance inclusion, maximise efficiency and strengthen trust," said J. Swaminathan, Deputy Governor of the Reserve Bank of India. Speaking at the 20th CUB V. Narayanan Memorial Lecture at SASTRA Campus in Thanjavur, he outlined a five-point charter for AI adoption in the Financial & Banking industry: human responsibility, fairness & explainability, strong data governance, institutional adoption maturity, and inclusivity by design. These points promote fair outcomes and transparency. "Financial decision making cannot be a black box theory and it requires tremendous institutional responsibility," added the DG. The event was attended by City Union Bank officials, banking professionals, and SASTRA faculty.

Fedha by Challani at Peravallur



Fedha by Challani showcases the elegance of silver jewellery, a timeless trend in contemporary fashion. Celebrated for its radiant shine and versatility, silver pieces such as earrings, necklaces, bracelets, and rings are perfect for both everyday wear and special occasions. Modern women are drawn to silver for its effortless style and affordability, offering beauty without compromise. Additionally, silver is skin-friendly, making it ideal for daily use. The Lavish Edition collection at Fedha includes a variety of handcrafted pieces that blend contemporary design with traditional influences. Inaugurated by Vani Bhojan in Peravallur, Perambur, this store establishes a new destination for exquisite silver jewellery in Chennai. Gifting silver has become a meaningful way to celebrate special moments.

Joyalukkas' Cashback Fest

Joyalukkas announced Cashback Fest from 10 to 20 April, for Akshaya Tritiya, across all showrooms, nationwide. As part of the celebration, Customers purchasing diamond, uncut diamond and platinum jewellery worth Rs. 75,000 and above will receive a Rs. 2,000 gift voucher. Those selecting gold and precious jewellery collections worth Rs.75,000 and above will receive a Rs. 1,000 gift voucher, while silver jewellery enthusiasts can enjoy a Rs. 500 gift voucher on purchases of Rs.15,000 and above. Dr. Joy Alukkas, Chairman and Managing Director of the Joyalukkas group, expressed his vision for this auspicious celebration stating, "Akshaya Tritiya represents a sacred time when prosperity multiplies and new ventures begin." The Akshaya Tritiya Cashback Fest provides customers with the perfect opportunity to explore Joyalukkas' extensive collections.

BIGGEST EXCHANGE, DISCOUNT, DEAL SALE

BIGGEST FURNITURE SUMMER EXPO



OPENS TODAY

17 | 18 | 19

APRIL 2026

10.00 AM TO 8.30 PM

CHENNAI TRADE CENTRE
NANDAMBAKKAM,
CHENNAI



• LIVING ROOM • DINING SET • BEDROOM • WOODEN FURNITURE • HOME DECOR • BRASS & ARTIFACTS
• RECLINER SOFA SETS • CARPET & CUSHIONS • MATTRESSES • CURTAINS • WATER FOUNTAINS

www.iadsandevents.com exhibitions_iadsnevents iadsnevents ENTRY FREE +91 7448767203

AN EVENT BY

iads & events
COMPLETE BUSINESS SOLUTIONS



The new Taigun

Welcome to driving

75% **ASSURED BUYBACK**

Price starting at ₹10.99 Lakh*



Call 1800 102 0909

Images are for representation purpose. Features and accessories shown may not be a part of standard equipment and are subject to change without prior notice. Actual colour of the car may vary. Price mentioned is ex-showroom price. Terms and conditions apply. Offer is extended by authorized Volkswagen dealerships and is subject to specific terms and conditions. Please contact your dealership to know more.

Authorised Dealers: Volkswagen Chennai: Nandanam-9500136129; Ambattur-9840036789; Volkswagen Madras: Anna Nagar- 8056099499; Alandur-9940057890; OMR-9500155532; Volkswagen Mount Road: Anna Salai-7708033322; Arcot road -9500155532; Volkswagen Kattupakkam: 7708033322; Volkswagen Pondicherry: 9840911716; Volkswagen Vellore: (0416) 2213373/83, 9344721666.



UNGAL VOTE YAARUKU??



YOUR VOTE. YOUR HOME. YOUR WIN.



UNGAL VOTE YAAARUKU??



YOUR VOTE. YOUR HOME. YOUR WIN.

The leap to ‘becoming the best in the world’

The 20-year-old Ayush Shetty’s run to the Badminton Asia Championships title clash on the back of victories over three top-10 players points to a significant transition for the sport in India

Devvyanshi Bihani

Ayush Shetty’s run to the final of the Badminton Asia Championships is not just a breakthrough result. It is the first time an Indian men’s singles player has reached this stage since Dinesh Khanna in 1965, and it comes on the back of a week that points to a larger transition in Indian badminton. India has produced players capable of beating top names. K. Srikanth and H.S. Pranoy in their peak, Lakshya Sen in recent years but has been missing is the ability to sustain those wins against the very top tier and string them together in a single tournament. In Ningbo, Ayush did exactly that.

Stellar show
He beat World No. 7 Li Shi Feng, followed it with a straight-games win over Chi Yu Jen, then defeated the then World No. 4 Jonatan Christie and World No. 1 Kunlavut Vitidsarn in the semifinals – before being comprehensively outplayed by Shi Yuqi in the final.

A few weeks after Lakshya took apart Li at the All England, it was another Indian’s turn to get the better of the Chinese. Ayush went back to the same fault line Lakshya had exposed: the forehand rear corner that pulls Li away from his base at the net. Early in rallies, he stepped in with interceptions and pushed the shuttle deep to that flank. On one such point, he casually used his racquet like a shield as Li’s mid-court smash came at him, and tapped it down. Forget Li, even Ayush had no time to see it. When the return came short or lifted, the finish was taken at full height, before Li could recover position. Even when the Chinese tried to drag Ayush into a long exchange he did not lose control. At 13-19 in the first game, he rode out the longest rally of the match and then put his stamp on it with a killer shot.

Against Chi Yu Jen, the same approach became even more visible because of the pace of exchanges. Much of the match was played in the forecourt, with Ayush staying low, blocking early and taking time away from the Taiwanese. A five-point burst at 14-13 in the first game, built on interceptions and tight dribbles, effectively broke the match open.

At 8-7 in the second, a flick serve was put away immediately with a smash, and in the next rally he stayed in a doubles style flat exchange to win the point. He closed the match the same way he built it, taking a 19-11 lead and finishing with a decisive attacking point.

The rallies did not open up as easily against Jonatan Christie in the quarterfinals. The Indian was chasing the game, trailing through phases at 7-10, 11-14 and 13-16. From 18-all, the match turned on shot selection. The Indonesian still reached game point after forcing a defensive lift long. But, Ayush took the first opening he got and dashed it with a cross-court smash to level and then stayed in the rally as the Indonesian faltered. The first game, 23-21, was not won on power. It was worked through.

During the second game, with the scoreboard in his favour, he went back to shorter points. The lifts were punished earlier, and Christie began to concede points under pressure: a poor leave at the backline, a loose lift that was finished, followed by errors long and wide.

“The length of the rallies were quite long considering the way Ayush has played in the previous tournaments where he played some very short rallies, not patient enough...here, he was excellent with his defence,” coach Sagar Chopda said.

The semifinal against Vitidsarn was the clearest marker of growth. It was the first time in the week he had to recover from going a game down and still impose his game.

The Thai controlled the opening game, taking it 21-10, and looked on course for

the final. But the Indian pushed back one of the quickest players on tour and made him cover both flanks. Early in the second, Ayush forced errors to go up 7-1, repeatedly targeting the forehand forecourt and drawing Vitidsarn into awkward lunges.

At 13-11, the cross-court smash returned and at 20-19, he closed the game with another. With the scoreboard against him in the third, Vitidsarn began to rush. Meanwhile, the lead stretched in Ayush’s favour from 7-2 to 17-10, and he eventually closed out the match 21-17.

Having shown that ability in the semifinal, a similar response was hoped for after he dropped the first game against Shi Yuqi in the final, but the challenge proved greater.

The final against Shi showed the next level. Ayush lost 8-21, 10-21 in 42 minutes. Shi dictated the match from the outset. He varied pace, controlled length, and, most importantly, kept the shuttle away from the youngster’s hitting zone. By doing that, he cut off the Indian’s biggest weapon before it could come into play.

“When we spoke to him, he said that it wasn’t the nerves, that was a very minor part,” said Sagar. “Shi was by far the better player today (Sunday). He really kept the pressure and never let me come back,” Ayush admitted. The attack was still there, but it was forced. “Ayush could have been a little more patient in playing those longer rallies. He was very impatient. Which was

The semifinal win over Vitidsarn was the clearest marker of Ayush’s growth as he recovered from going a game down and still imposed himself on the then World No. 1

not the case in the previous four matches...he was prepared to grind it out and then when he got an opportunity, he went for those hard ones,” added Sagar.

There were also phases where the match could have shifted. Ayush started the second game well, building a 7-2 lead. But a cluster of errors handed the initiative back. Against top players, those lapses are enough.

“There is a lot of learning... I have to work on my endurance, strength and variations from the back,” Ayush said.

From volatility to control, earlier this season, Ayush’s results did not reflect his ability. He lost a series of close matches, to Indonesia’s 20-year-old Alwi Farhan and to compatriot Lakshya. The frustration kept building, and it finally broke at the Swiss Open after the loss to Canada’s Brian Yang, when he bent his racquet until it snapped clean in two.

“At that stage, it was also self-imposed pressure of performance. Toward the end of last season, he broke into the top 30...once you start doing well, people expect you to keep doing well. But every athlete handles emotions differently,”

said Sagar. He was also managing a back issue and did not communicate it early, choosing instead to play through the pain. Since then, two things have changed. First, he has been working with a sports psychologist over the last few months. Second, his on-court responses have eventually become more composed.

What stood out last week, more than the smash, the early interceptions or the no-look tap, was the structure around his game: tighter net play, quicker transitions, and improved control.

At 6’4”, Ayush fits the physical template of the game as the recently retired legend Viktor Axelsen had remarked that he “reminds me of my younger self.” The height can also pose challenges, but he said he learned valuable lessons during a training stint with Axelsen in Dubai last year.

He also began training with coach Irwansyah two weeks before the Asian Championships. “He has adapted very quickly to my programme, but there are still many things he can work on to improve his performance. But with the motivation, hard work and discipline he has already shown in the last few weeks I believe Ayush will win many tournaments,” said Irwansyah.

As his new sparring partner P.V. Sindhu put it, he is “a generational talent.”

The question now is no longer who comes next. With Ayush, the more interesting question might be: what comes next?

THE GIST

Srikanth and Pranoy in their peak had beaten the finest in the business, but the ability to sustain those wins against the very top tier has been missing

At 6’4”, Ayush fits the physical template of the game as the recently retired legend Axelsen had remarked that he “reminds me of my younger self”

Ayush had begun training with coach Irwansyah two weeks before the BAC in Ningbo

BADMINTON ASIA CHAMPIONSHIPS



HEALTH

Why India should establish a vaccine injury compensation mechanism

When the state strongly promotes vaccination as a civic duty, it must also accept responsibility for those who bear the rare but real costs of that collective effort: it is incumbent upon India now to enact a policy and set up a mechanism to compensate those who suffer adverse effects following immunisation

Yashweer Singh

In the winter of 2021, millions of Indians lined up outside government health centres to receive COVID-19 vaccines. They were responding to public calls from official campaigns and, in many contexts, were effectively mandated by employers and institutions. With over 219.86 crore doses administered by late 2022, vaccination was not merely a personal choice but a social contract. What was never made equally clear was what would happen to those who, through no fault of their own, suffered serious harm because they answered that call.

India's silence on vaccine injuries is a governance deficit that cuts to the heart of constitutional accountability and the social compact between citizens and the state. Now, the Supreme Court has directed the Union government, in the *Rachana Gangu v. Union of India* (2026) case, to frame a no-fault compensation policy for serious adverse events following COVID-19 vaccination.

Rare but real

Vaccines are among the most consequential public health innovations in human history. Their role in eliminating smallpox, nearly eradicating polio, and dramatically reducing child mortality is beyond dispute. Yet the medical literature is equally unambiguous that serious adverse events following immunisation, while rare, do occur. Anaphylaxis, thrombosis with thrombocytopenia syndrome (TTS) linked to certain adenoviral vector vaccines, vaccine-associated paralytic polio from oral polio formulations, and encephalopathy following some childhood vaccines are all documented.

The rarity of these events is not a reason to dismiss them. It is the very reason a compensation mechanism becomes ethically necessary. When a harm is rare and unpredictable, the individual who suffers it is just someone who took a risk on behalf of collective immunity and lost. The government's own affidavit recorded 92,114 Adverse Events Following Immunisation (AEFI) cases, including 89,332 minor, 2,782 serious or severe AEFIs, and 1,171 deaths.

Protecting public health

The Constitution does not merely permit the State to run vaccination programmes, but creates an affirmative obligation to protect public health as part of the right to life under Article 21, which includes the right to health. If the state derives legitimacy from promoting collective welfare through mandatory interventions, it must also bear the duty to remedy harm caused by those interventions. The “doctrine of legitimate expectation” supports this, as citizens who comply with state health directives may legitimately expect not to be abandoned if compliance causes injury. A wealthy individual can access specialists and courts; a daily-wage worker who suffers



The big shot: Vaccines are among the most consequential public health innovations in human history. Yet the medical literature is equally unambiguous that serious adverse events following immunisation, while rare, do occur. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

post-vaccination paralysis cannot, making the absence of a scheme not a neutral gap but a deeply unequal one.

Existing legal remedies for vaccine injury are poorly suited to the problem. Tort law requires proof of fault that the manufacturer or state acted below the required standard of care. Where a serious adverse event occurs because of individual immune response rather than any error, there is simply no fault to establish and no cause of action to bring. The Consumer Protection Act 2019, allows claims for deficiency in service. However, where vaccines are supplied free, the ‘consumer’ relationship is legally contested, and consumer forums are ill-equipped to assess pharmacovigilance evidence.

Even PILs are too blunt an instrument for individual compensation. A PIL can direct policy, as the Supreme Court has now done, but it cannot administer a claims process, leaving the legal ecosystem structurally incapable of uniform redress.

Practices abroad

India is not starting from scratch in a conceptual sense. The no-fault vaccine injury compensation model has been road-tested widely. In the U.S., the Vaccine Injury Compensation Programme operates through a dedicated federal ‘vaccine court’ where claimants bear a lower evidentiary standard and are compensated from a trust fund levied on manufacturers, saying that the burden of collective immunity shall not be privately borne.

The U.K.’s Vaccine Damage Payment Scheme provides a fixed lump-sum payment to those who suffer severe

Vaccination is a social bargain. The individual accepts a small, quantifiable risk so that the community is protected from a larger one

disablement from a covered vaccination, without requiring proof of negligence. Japan, Germany, New Zealand, and several Nordic countries maintain comparable no-fault frameworks. Taiwan processed thousands of COVID-19 compensation claims within months of rollout, offering a model that India should study.

A framework for India

India requires a Vaccine Injury Compensation Act, not a circular, which can be quietly withdrawn between elections, but a Parliamentary statute with defined rights and independent oversight. Second, a no-fault presumptive causation table is needed. The law should maintain a ‘Vaccine Injury Table’: conditions occurring within a specified time window following a specific vaccine are presumed to be caused by it, shifting the evidentiary default toward the injured while allowing the state to rebut in exceptional cases. Third, an independent administrative tribunal is required.

Claims should be decided by a dedicated quasi-judicial body with medical and legal expertise, accessible without mandatory legal representation. Fourth, a dedicated compensation fund must be set up. Funding should be shared between the Central government and vaccine manufacturers through a levy system, aligning manufacturers’ interests

with vigilant post-market surveillance rather than incentivising suppression. Fifth, transparent AEFI reporting must be prioritised. India must strengthen its surveillance system through mandatory disaggregated state-level reporting, independent audits and public dashboards, as a compensation framework is only as credible as the data behind it.

The trust dividend

Sceptics may argue that a compensation scheme emboldens anti-vaccination sentiment. The comparative evidence suggests the opposite: robust compensation systems consistently correlate with higher voluntary vaccination uptake. Trust is built not through silence about risk, but through transparency and accountability, and with India’s recently launched massive HPV vaccination programme, it becomes urgent.

Vaccination is a social bargain. The individual accepts a small, quantifiable risk so that the community is protected from a larger, diffuse one. When the state manages, promotes, or mandates that bargain, it becomes a party to it. A party to a bargain that causes harm bears responsibility for that harm. What India’s legislature, Health Ministry, and legal community must now ensure is that the policy that emerges is not a minimalist gesture of compliance but a genuine institutional commitment, one that honours, finally and formally, the price some citizens pay for the protection of all.

(Yashweer Singh is a penultimate year student at Gujarat National Law University, Gandhinagar. yashweerr@gmail.com)

THE GIST

India’s silence on vaccine injuries is a governance deficit that cuts to the heart of constitutional accountability and the social compact between citizens and the State.

Existing legal remedies for vaccine injury are poorly suited to the problem. Tort law requires proof of fault that the manufacturer or state acted below the required standard of care

India requires a Vaccine Injury Compensation Act, not a circular, which can be quietly withdrawn between elections, but a Parliamentary statute with defined rights and independent oversight

HUMERUS



Understanding Parkinson’s disease and its symptoms

Serena Josephine M.

April marks Parkinson’s disease Awareness Month, highlighting the need for early recognition of this progressive neurodegenerative disorder and the importance of support groups for patients and caregivers. Though awareness has improved, healthcare providers still find delayed diagnosis a major challenge as symptoms are often overlooked or misunderstood. Identifying the condition early and starting appropriate treatment can help manage symptoms effectively and improve quality of life, they say.

Natesan Damodaran, clinical lead, epilepsy and functional neurosurgery, Rela Hospital, Chennai, said compared to 10 years ago, the awareness of Parkinson’s disease is definitely getting better. “One of the main challenges that we face is people missing a diagnosis. Some patients may have tremors in the hand, but may think that this is due to generalised tiredness or nerve weakness. So, by the time they reach a neurologist for a proper evaluation, diagnosis is delayed.”

There are three cardinal symptoms of Parkinson’s disease, Dr. Damodaran said: “Tremors or shaking



Tremors or shaking of hands is one of the symptom of Parkinson’s disease. ISTOCKPHOTO

of hands is one of them. Slowness is the other main symptom. They may walk slowly or drink coffee slowly. Tightness (rigidity) is the third symptom of this disease.”

Vivek Iyer, joint director and senior consultant, neurology, SIMS Hospital, Chennai, pointed out that patients with Parkinson’s are usually in the fifth or sixth decade of their life. Constipation and rapid eye movement, sleep behaviour disorders such acting out of dreams or violent movements during sleep are the cardinal non-motor symptoms that can predate onset of motor symptoms by one or two decades. Most patients

do not present to a neurologist if non-motor symptoms are predominant, resulting in delays in diagnosis, he explained.

Dr. Damodaran said that appropriate diagnosis is crucial. The ultimate goal of treatment, he added, is providing a good quality of life. “Enabling patients to be independent is the aim,” he said.

Though, currently there is no cure for Parkinson’s disease, early detection is vital in order to slow down the progress of the disease and control symptoms. Medicines can be prescribed according to the symptoms – tremor, rigidity and emotional disturbances, he said.

Surgical treatment

Dr. Iyer said that Deep Brain Stimulation (DBS) was a surgical treatment offered for Parkinson’s disease. However, it may not be suitable for all patients. There is also adaptive DBS, a technology which can be programmed as per the patient’s needs. This adapts to specific symptoms in patients such as tremors or stiffness. It can automatically adjust electrical stimulation in real time, based on the brain’s activity. “MR-guided focused ultrasound treatment is for tremor dominant

Parkinson’s disease and other varieties of tremors, available in select centres in India,” he added.

For a condition like Parkinson’s disease, support groups play an important role not only for patients but also their caregivers. “A support system is essential for patients and their caregivers. For patients, it is a common forum where they can discuss their problems and get a chance to undergo physiotherapy, psychotherapy, psychological counselling and occupational therapy. For caregivers, it helps understand the disease and help avoid burn out,” said Shubha Subramanian, senior consultant, neurology, Kauvery Hospital, Vadapalani, Chennai.

Though there are a number of support groups, not many are aware of them. This gap needs to be addressed, she said.

In Chennai, a number of hospitals have patient support groups. These groups get together every month and discuss support and care including speech therapy, physical exercises, physiotherapy, and measures essential to maintain functional independence. Such groups can help address day to day challenges faced by patients and their caregivers. (serena.m@thehindu.co.in)

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount sought by Finland from EU for undersea cable repairs

11.25 in \$ million. Finland has applied for 9.55 million euros (\$11.25 million) in funding from the European Commission to reinforce its undersea cable repair capacity, the Finnish ministry of transport and communications said on Thursday. The Baltic Sea region has been on high alert for sabotage after a string of outages of power cables. REUTERS

Number of weeks of jet fuel supply that Europe has remaining

6 Europe has “maybe 6 weeks or so (of) jet fuel left,” the head of the International Energy Agency (IEA) said on Thursday, warning of possible flight cancellations “soon” if oil supplies remain blocked by the Iran war. The IEA warned of global repercussions from what he called “the largest energy crisis we have ever faced,” stemming from the pinch-off of oils through the Strait of Hormuz. AP

Percentage growth in China’s economy in this year’s first quarter

5 in per cent. China’s economy grew by five per cent in the first quarter of this year, exceeding expectations despite the global fallout from the US-Israel war. The first three months of GDP generated 33.4 trillion yuan (about USD 4.87 trillion), accelerating by 0.5 percentage points from the fourth quarter of 2025, data from China’s National Bureau of Statistics showed on Thursday. PTI

Decline in India’s inbound tourism since West Asia crisis began

15-20 in per cent. India’s inbound tourist traffic declined 15-20 per cent since the West Asia crisis broke out, while the aviation industry is staring at an estimated net loss of ₹18,000 crore, following disruptions caused by the conflict, according to a report on the impact of the West Asia conflict released on Thursday. PTI

Number of West African nationals rescued by Ghana

305 More than 300 West African nationals, including 113 children, have been rescued after an intelligence-led bust by the Ghana Immigration Service on street begging networks in the capital of Accra, the agency said on Thursday. The operation early Wednesday targeted suspected street begging rings. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us [facebook.com/thehindu](#) [X.com/the_hindu](#) [instagram.com/the_hindu](#)

On the Sabarimala temple entry case

As a Supreme Court Bench examines the broader implications of its 2018 Sabarimala ruling, the case prompts a look into the evolution of the essential religious practice doctrine, role of the State and the judiciary in religious reform, and the arguments over whether Ayyappa followers qualify as a religious denomination

LETTER AND SPIRIT

Kartikey Singh
Monalisa Nanda

The story so far:

A nine-judge Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court (SC), led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, is currently hearing petitions relating to discrimination against women at religious places, examining the correctness and broader constitutional implications of its 2018 ruling in *Indian Young Lawyers’ Association vs. State of Kerala* on women’s entry into the Sabarimala Temple in Kerala.

On September 28, 2018, a five-judge Constitution Bench of the apex court, by a 4:1 majority, struck down the age-based restriction, declaring Rule 3(b) of the Kerala Hindu Places of Public Worship (Authorisation of Entry) Rules, 1965 – which permitted ‘religious denominations’ to exclude women from public places of worship on grounds of custom – as unconstitutional. The exclusion of women of “menstruating age” violated the guarantees of equality, non-discrimination and dignity, the apex court had held. It further ruled that devotees of Lord Ayyappa do not constitute a separate ‘religious denomination’, and that the said custom does not qualify as an “essential religious practice” (ERP).

Balancing religious freedom and equality

Articles 25-28 under Part III (Fundamental Rights) of the Constitution guarantee the right to freedom of religion, with the Sabarimala matter focused on the interplay between Articles 25 and 26. While Article 25 secures to “all persons” the freedom of conscience and the right to profess, practise, and propagate religion, Article 26 protects the autonomy of ‘religious denominations’ to manage their own affairs in matters of religion, establish institutions, and acquire and administer property. Both rights are subject to ‘public order’, ‘morality’, and ‘health’, with Article 25 additionally limited by ‘other fundamental rights’. Framed against the backdrop of India’s religious diversity, these provisions safeguard the beliefs and practices of all faiths.

The doctrinal foundation for interpreting these provisions lies in *Sri Lakshmindra Thirtha Swamiar of Shirur Mutt* (1954), where the Supreme Court held that religion also includes practices essential to the faith while distinguishing them from secular activities, particularly administration, property and finance, which remain amenable to state regulation. This sacred-secular distinction is decided through the ERP doctrine, which requires courts to assess, with reference to religious texts and tenets, whether a practice is integral to a faith, i.e., whether its absence would fundamentally alter the religion itself, as was clarified in *Acharya Jagdishwarananda Avadhuta* (2004). The doctrine seeks to balance ‘religious autonomy’ with ‘constitutional accountability’.

Union government’s contentions

The Union government, led by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, had advanced three primary contentions: first, that “constitutional morality” is inherently subjective and not an independent ground of judicial review; second, that



On September 28, 2018, the Supreme Court struck down the ban on entry of women of ‘menstruating age’ into the Sabarimala temple. PTI

judges should not be social reformers, which must instead emanate from the legislature and society; and third, that the judiciary is ill-equipped to determine ERPs, as the Constitution leaves questions of religious essentiality to the faith itself. Building on this, the Union further argued that the 2018 ruling failed to account for the internal plurality of Indian religions and the phrase “any section thereof” in Article 26, which, it contends, extends denominational protection to sub-groups within a faith.

Moreover, Mr. Mehta, citing the example of temples where men are excluded, and a Kerala temple where men enter dressed as women, argued that religions may impose male or female-centric restrictions, which have nothing to do with gender stereotypes or patriarchy. In a related vein, the application of Article 17 (abolition of untouchability) to the exclusion of women was contested on the ground that it is historically confined to caste-based practices and cannot be extended to biological conditions such as menstruation without distorting its constitutional purpose.

On conducting reforms in religion

At its core, the issue turns to how the Constitution distinguishes between protected religious practices and those amenable to reform. While Article 25(1) guarantees freedom of conscience and religion, Article 25(2) permits regulation of secular activities associated with religious practice. During the Constituent Assembly debates, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar pointed out the need to separate what is “essentially religious” from secular activities intertwined with religion, advocating limits on religious definitions to allow State intervention in non-essential practices. Yet, despite the Constitutional provision not clearly demarcating this boundary, the framers’ intent was to protect all practices that are inherently and essentially religious under Article 25(1) – a position now narrowed by the evolving ERP doctrine, which shifts the inquiry from whether a practice is inherently religious to whether it is indispensable to a religion’s core identity.

In doing so, the judicial position taken in earlier cases adjudicated by the top court between 1950 and 1980, including that in *Mahant Sri Jagannath Ramanuj Das* (1954) and *Seshammal* (1972), is undone.

These verdicts recognised that Article 25(1) protects not only doctrine but also rituals, observances, ceremonies, and modes of worship, i.e., all practices that are essentially religious and not merely things that have scriptural backing to be “essential to the religion”. This stands in contrast to later rulings such as *Adi Saiva Sivachariyargal* (2015) and *Indian Young Lawyers’ Association* (2018), wherein the Supreme Court held that even if there is proof of a certain practice being followed since pre-constitutional times, it cannot be afforded protection under Article 25(1) if it is not essential to the core functions of the religion. This pattern points to a gradual narrowing of the religious protections afforded under Article 25(1), with the court allowing for practices and rituals falling at the periphery of religious practice to be reformed.

Importantly, Article 25(2)(a) allows the ‘State’ to make laws regulating secular functions associated with religion while also empowering it under Article 25(2)(b) to provide for social welfare or reforms. Article 25(2)(b) was originally designed to dismantle caste-based exclusion in Hindu religious institutions, not gender-based restrictions. As reflected in the Constituent Assembly debates, particularly the views of K.M. Munshi and Dr. B. R. Ambedkar, the phrase “all persons are equally entitled” emerged in the context of caste and communal inequities. Accordingly, gender equality claims are better grounded in Articles 14 and 15, rather than by expanding Article 25(2)(b).

Thus, the Constitutional text reflects the framers’ intent to vest the power of reform in the State, which must calibrate such measures in a manner that is aligned with the needs of its constituents.

So, what role does the judiciary play? While Article 25(2) vests the power of reform in the State, courts retain the authority to intervene where religious practices (like witchcraft or human sacrifice) offend public order, morality or health. Therefore, a combined reading of Articles 25 (1) and (2) indicates that, while the State has the power to actively pursue social reforms in matters of religion with a limited scope of application of “transformative constitutionalism” by the courts, the judiciary retains the power to strike down practices that may be completely abhorrent to the spirit of a democratic society.

The definition of religious denomination

Religious denominations or sects enjoy a special set of rights under Article 26, extending beyond the general protections under Article 25, including autonomy in managing religious affairs. Additionally, while the right under Article 25 is subject to all other fundamental rights, the same is not the case with the ‘denominational rights’ granted under Article 26, making the “denomination” status extremely covetable.

In *Shirur Mutt* (1954), the apex court adopted the Oxford Dictionary meaning of “denomination” and laid down a three-part test to be fulfilled by a group of individuals to qualify as a denomination – (1) common faith, (2) common organisation, and (3) designation by a distinct name. Applying this in the *Indian Young Lawyers’ Association* (2018), the SC denied denominational status to Ayyappa devotees, holding that they were not distinct from the broader Hindu faith, particularly as the temple permitted entry to Hindus across sects rather than exclusively to Ayyappa followers.

However, critics often rely on an argument tracing the origins of Article 26 to propound for denominational rights to the devotees of Ayyappa Swami. Article 26 of the Indian Constitution is borrowed from Article 44 of the Irish Constitution from 1937, which at one point in time, specifically enumerated denominations like the Methodist Church of Ireland, the Presbyterian Church in Ireland, and so on. Therefore, the expression “religious denomination” is one that was originally used in the context of clearly defined and organised Christian sects. This definition, when juxtaposed in the context of Hinduism’s open architectural background, often loses meaning, as sects often do not function independently of the primary Hindu tenets.

Presumably to account for this difference, the framers of the Constitution extended denominational rights to every religious denomination “or any section thereof” under Article 26(1). This allows for a scenario where sections of a larger faith, even if not completely distinct from the said faith, enjoy ‘denominational rights’ available under the provision. (*Kartikey Singh is a lawyer based in New Delhi. Monalisa Nanda is a lawyer and public policy professional. Views expressed are personal.*)

THE GIST

Articles 25-28 under Part III (Fundamental Rights) of the Constitution guarantee the right to freedom of religion, with the Sabarimala matter focused on the interplay between Articles 25 and 26.

The Union government argued that “constitutional morality” is subjective and not an independent ground for judicial review; that judges should not act as social reformers, with reforms instead emanating from the legislature and society; and that the judiciary is ill-equipped to determine essential religious practices.

At its core, the issue turns to how the Constitution distinguishes between protected religious practices and those amenable to reform.

